

The Winter Term

A Dark Academia Mystery

by Maren Ashcroft

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The Arrival

The train emptied at Newcastle and did not fill again. By Hexham there were four people left in the carriage, and three of them got off ahead of her with the confidence of people going home.

Nell Kavanagh stayed in her seat until the doors began to beep, because she had spent eleven days being told she was going somewhere and she wanted one more minute of being nowhere. Then she took her case down from the rack, and the case was heavier than she remembered packing it, and she stepped onto a platform that smelled of cold iron and diesel and something green underneath, wet grass, maybe, or moss on stone.

It was ten past three in the afternoon and the light was already going.

The letter had come on the nineteenth of December. She had read it at the kitchen table in Hull with her coat still on, because the heating went off at nine and it was twenty past. The Pemberton Scholarship, full fees and boarding, Ravensfell College, Northumberland. Commencing the winter term. Her mother had read it after her, twice, and had said only, they don't do that. They don't just give it to you in December.

They had given it to her in December.

A man in a green quilted jacket was holding a piece of card with RAVENSFELL written on it in marker, and under that, smaller, KAVANAGH. He did not look up when she came over. He looked at the case.

"That all of it?"

"That's all of it."

"Right," he said, and took it from her, and she let him, and felt immediately that letting him had been the wrong choice, that a girl from the right sort of family

would have kept hold of her own case, or would have had a trunk, or would not have come alone on a Tuesday in January with a rail ticket bought with her mother's card.

The minibus was warm and smelled of wet dog. They went out of the town and up, and the road narrowed, and the hedges gave way to drystone walls, and then the walls gave way to nothing at all except moor, brown and flattened and rimed white in the hollows where the sun had not reached since November. Fog sat in the valley bottoms like water in a basin. Once she saw sheep, standing very still, facing the same direction.

"You'll not have been up here before," the driver said. It was not a question.

"No."

"Aye," he said, satisfied, and did not speak again for eleven miles.

The college came out of the fog all at once, the way a ship does. She had seen photographs. The photographs had been taken in June, and in the photographs there had been grass, and long shadows, and a cricket score chalked on a board, and the stone had looked honey coloured. The stone was not honey coloured. It was the grey of a wet pavement, four storeys of it, with two long ranks of sash windows and a square clock tower on the left, and behind it the roofline simply stopped, dissolved, because the fog had come up the valley and taken the top of the building away.

Three windows were lit. Everything else was dark.

"Front steps," the driver said. "You go up. They'll be expecting."

They were not expecting.

She stood in the entrance hall for eleven minutes by the clock over the door, holding her case, while a woman in a grey cardigan telephoned two extensions and got no answer from either. The hall had a black and white stone floor and it was colder inside than it had been on the steps. There were boards on the walls with names painted on them in gold, hundreds of names, going back and back, and Nell read them because there was nothing else to do. Head of School. Head of School. Head of School. 1912, 1913, 1914, and then 1915 and 1916 and 1917 with no names at all, just the years, and then names again.

"Kavanagh," said the woman, hanging up. "That's the scholarship."

"Yes."

The woman looked at her properly for the first time. It was not an unkind look. It was the look of someone checking a delivery against a docket.

"You're the Pemberton."

"I am, yes."

"Well," the woman said. "That was quick."

Nell did not know what to say to that, so she said nothing, and the woman seemed to feel she had said something she had not meant to, because she became brisk, and found a key on a board of keys, and wrote in a ledger, and turned the ledger round for Nell to sign, and Nell signed under a line that had been left blank.

"West Tower, room fourteen. Supper's at half six in Hall, you'll hear the bell. Miss Renard's in the tower, she'll show you." The woman paused. "You'll want your coat on. The tower's not heated in the day."

While the woman wrote, Nell looked at the two things on the desk that were not paper.

One was a photograph in a frame, turned away from her, of a dog.

The other was a wooden board with a hundred small hooks in it and a key on every hook, and beside it, on the wall, a printed list of rooms and buildings that had been typed once and corrected in biro perhaps thirty times over perhaps thirty years, so that the newest entries were in a different hand from the oldest and one of them had been crossed out twice and rewritten.

It was the first thing Nell saw at Ravensfell College that she understood completely: an institution that never threw anything away and never quite kept it either. She would spend the next ten weeks finding out how much of the school was made of that, and how much of what she needed had been sitting on a wall in the open the whole time, in biro, waiting for somebody to read it.

The corridor to the West Tower was long and the floor sloped. Nell had read about the sloping floors in the prospectus, where it had been called a charming quirk of the eighteenth century foundations, and walking it with a case she found it was not charming, it was just a slope, and her case wanted to go left.

A girl was coming the other way with an armful of books, and stopped, and stepped aside to let her past, and then did not let her past.

"You're new."

"I'm new."

"In January," the girl said.

"In January."

The girl was perhaps her own age, dark haired, with a face that gave nothing away for free. She had a book open against her chest with a finger keeping the place, and she did not close it.

"Which room."

"Fourteen."

Something happened in the girl's face then. It was very small. It was not shock, and it was not distress, and afterwards, lying awake, Nell would spend a long time trying to name it and would settle in the end on the word recognition, which was not right either, but was the closest she could get. It was the look of someone hearing a piece of news they had already been told.

"Right," the girl said. "I'm Margot. I'm in fifteen."

"Nell."

"Nell what."

"Kavanagh."

"Kavanagh," Margot repeated, and there was a very slight foreign shape to the way she took the word, French, Nell thought, and she said it again, quietly, as if putting it somewhere. "All right. Come up, then. The stairs are the worst part and then it stops being awful."

The stairs were the worst part. There were sixty-one of them, stone, worn into shallow dishes in the middle by three hundred years of feet, and they turned twice, and there was no rail for the last flight. At the top there was a landing with four doors and a window that had frozen on the inside, actual ice, in a fern pattern, on the inside of the glass.

Margot stopped outside the door with fourteen on it in brass and did not open it.

"They said someone was coming," she said. "They didn't say when."

"They told me on the nineteenth of December."

"Yes," Margot said. "They would have."

She opened the door.

The room was small and high and had one window facing north over the moor, and a bed, and a desk, and a wardrobe, and a wash basin with a tap that dripped. It was cold in the specific way of rooms that have been cold for a long time. There was a rug on the floorboards that had been beaten but not recently.

And there were clothes in the wardrobe. The wardrobe door was open a hand's width, and there was a green coat in it, and two shirts, and a dress in a dry cleaner's bag with the ticket still stapled to it.

Nell stood with her case in the doorway.

"Sorry," she said, "is someone in here?"

Margot looked at the wardrobe for a moment. Just a moment. Then she crossed the room and shut the door of it with her hip, the way you shut a door you have shut many times, and picked up a hairbrush from the desk and put it in her cardigan pocket in one movement, without looking at it.

"No," she said. "Nobody's in here."

"But the clothes."

"They haven't collected them yet," Margot said. "It's been a year. They keep saying they'll send someone."

She was at the door already. She stopped there, with her hand on the frame, and looked back at Nell standing in the middle of somebody else's room, still holding her case, in her coat, in the last of the light.

"Supper's at half six," she said. "You'll hear the bell. Don't be late on your first night, they notice."

And then, from halfway down the stairs, not loudly, not really to Nell at all:

"Her name was Cassia."

Room Fourteen

The bell went at twenty-five past six and Nell was ready at twenty past, which she understood within four minutes of arriving in Hall had been a mistake.

Nobody else was ready. They came in loose and late and talking, in coats over their uniforms, in scarves, one boy in cricket whites for no reason anyone explained, and they filled the long tables from the middle outward, so that Nell, who had come early and sat at the end of a bench near the door because it was the first empty place she saw, spent the meal in a gap. On her left, three feet of empty pine. On her right, a fourth year who answered two questions politely and then turned to her own side of the conversation and stayed there.

The food was good. That surprised her. Lamb, and potatoes done in a way she did not have a name for, and a jug of gravy per table that people used without looking, and afterwards a pudding with custard. At home in December they had eaten a lot of pasta. She ate everything on her plate and then was embarrassed at how clean the plate was and left a potato on the second helping, which she did not want and had taken because it was there.

At the high table, six adults ate more slowly. One of them was a woman in a dark green jumper with her hair pinned up, and twice during the meal Nell looked up and found that the woman was looking at her, and both times the woman did not look away, and simply went on looking for a moment longer, and then returned to her plate.

The bell went again at ten past seven. Everyone stood. Nell stood late.

Going out, in the crush at the door, a boy she had not seen arrive fell into step beside her as though they were already halfway through a conversation.

"You're Kavanagh," he said. "You're in the tower. I'm Sam. I'm the other one."

"The other what."

"The other scholarship." He had a mug of tea he had taken from the Hall, which she was fairly sure was not allowed, and he drank from it as they walked. "There are two of us in a hundred and forty. Which means at some point this term someone will introduce us to each other as if that's a thing we have in common, so I thought I'd get it out of the way myself and spare us both."

She laughed. It came out before she could decide whether to let it.

"Where are you from," he said.

"Hull."

"Manchester. Moss Side, originally, then Whalley Range, which people here say back to me as though it's a rank." He took another mouthful of tea. "First piece of advice. When they ask you where you're from, say the county, not the town. Northumberland people, they can place a town in about a second and a half and then they've decided. Say Yorkshire and watch the difference."

"That's cynical."

"It's Tuesday," Sam said. "Ask me again on a Friday, I'll be worse."

At the foot of the West Tower stairs he stopped and did not come up, and she understood that boys did not, or that this boy did not, and she was glad of the small clean edge of a rule she had not had to be told.

"Nell," he said. She had not told him her first name. "Room fourteen."

"Yes."

"Right." He looked into his mug. "It's a good room. It's the best room in the tower. North light. You'll want the window shut, though, the catch is broken and it comes open in the night and you'll wake up thinking someone's in there with you."

"Thanks."

"Night, then."

She was eleven steps up before she thought to wonder how he knew about the catch.

The room was colder than it had been at four. She put on her coat, and then her dressing gown over the coat, and sat on the bed and looked at the wardrobe with the door shut.

For half an hour she did not open it. She unpacked instead, which took nine minutes, because she had two jumpers and four shirts and one skirt and the uniform they had posted her in a plastic sleeve, and her books, which took up more room than her clothes. She put her father's watch on the desk, face up, the way it had sat

on the windowsill at home. It had stopped in 2019 and she had never had it mended.

Then she opened the wardrobe.

The green coat was wool, and good, and heavier than anything she owned. The two shirts were school issue. The dress in the dry cleaner's bag was dark red and had been cleaned and never collected, and the ticket stapled to the bag said 04/01, which was ten days before the fourteenth of January, and a name, BRANDT C.

There were shoes at the bottom, two pairs, and a hockey stick, and a shoebox.

She should not have opened the shoebox. She knew that while she was doing it. It was full of the ordinary sediment of a person: ticket stubs, a phone charger, three tubes of the same lipstick, a birthday card from someone called Aunt Ro, a photograph of five people on the steps of the chapel squinting into the sun, and a small brass key on a loop of green thread.

She looked at the photograph for a long time, sitting on the floor with her back to the open wardrobe and the light of the desk lamp coming over her shoulder.

Five of them on the chapel steps in summer. A tall boy in the middle with his arms out along the shoulders of the two next to him, laughing at whoever held the camera. A girl with her head tipped back, mouth open, mid shriek or mid song. A fair boy at the edge, not touching anyone, looking at the others rather than at the lens. Margot, unmistakably Margot, sitting a step lower with her arms round her own knees and her chin up, the only one of the five looking directly into the camera and not smiling.

And on the far left, half out of frame, a girl in a green coat in July.

Nell held the photograph closer to the lamp. It was July, or June, there were leaves on the elms behind the chapel and someone in the background was carrying a deckchair, and the girl on the left was wearing a heavy winter coat, and had her hands pushed into the pockets of it, and was the only one not squinting because she was in the shadow of the doorway.

The same coat. Six feet away, on a hanger, in the dark of the wardrobe.

Behind the five of them the chapel door stood open, and inside the doorway, hanging down out of the dark, there was a rope with a worn leather grip on the end of it, and Nell, who had grown up in a city and had never in her life been inside a building where anybody had to pull anything to make a noise, looked at it without a single thought, and turned the photograph over.

On the back, in pencil, in a hand that sloped hard to the right: all six of us, which was wrong, because there were five.

Nell put the lid back on the box and put the box back in the wardrobe and shut the door and sat down on the floor with her back against it, and her heart was going far too hard for a girl sitting on a floor.

A year, Margot had said. It had been a year.

Nobody leaves a coat like that. Nobody leaves a dress they have had cleaned. People leave lipsticks, and chargers, and hockey sticks. They do not leave the good coat in a building where the inside of the window freezes.

She got up. She made the bed properly, with the blanket squared, because her mother did that and it was ten past ten at night and she wanted something to do with her hands. She turned the mattress back to tuck the sheet under, and the mattress was heavy, and she got it up onto its edge and held it there with her knee.

There was a piece of paper on the slats.

It was flimsy, the sort of near transparent paper that comes in a book of carbon copies, and it had a printed heading, RAVENSFELL COLLEGE LAUNDRY, and a room number, 14, and a list of items in a column with numbers beside them, and along the bottom a date stamped in purple ink.

15 JAN.

Nell sat on the floor for the second time that night, with the mattress leaning against her shoulder and the laundry docket in her hand, and read it four times.

Two shirts. One skirt. One nightdress. Two pairs of socks. Received, room 14, 15 January.

The next morning she would ask Margot when Cassia Brandt had left, and Margot would say the fourteenth, without pausing, without thinking, the way you say a date you have said a great many times. The fourteenth of January.

But on the fifteenth of January somebody had sent two shirts and a skirt and a nightdress down from room fourteen to be washed.

She put the docket inside the cover of her Greek grammar, which was the only thing she owned that nobody else would ever pick up, and she put the mattress down, and she lay on it in her coat and her dressing gown with the light off.

At some point in the night the window came open, exactly as Sam had said it would, with a sound like someone taking a breath, and she lay in the dark with her eyes wide and did not get up to shut it for a long time.

The Seminar

The Fenn Room was on the first floor of the old block, and it had a fire in it, an actual fire, burning actual coal, which Nell had not seen in a room where people were expected to work since she was small enough to be taken to her grandmother's.

There were eight chairs round a long table and six of them were taken when she came in at two minutes to nine. She took the chair nearest the door. Everybody else had come in through the door and gone past it, to the far end, to the fire.

"Kavanagh," said Dr. Fenn, without looking up from the papers she was squaring. "Not there. Here."

The empty chair at the near end of the table on Dr. Fenn's right had been left, Nell understood too late, deliberately.

She moved. Somebody made room for her bag. The room was warm at that end and she was aware of her hands, which were red, and of the sleeves of her jumper, which had been washed a great many times.

"Right," Dr. Fenn said. "Antigone. Whose turn."

A tall boy at the far end said, "Mine," in the voice of someone who had been looking forward to it all Christmas, and read for four minutes in Greek, well, and then translated, less well, and Dr. Fenn let him get to the end before she took the passage apart in three sentences.

Then she went round the table.

Nell had read Antigone in a paperback with a broken spine that had cost her one pound fifty in a charity shop on Newland Avenue and had a boy's name written inside the cover in biro. She had read it four times. She had read it once out loud, in

her room, at fifteen, because she wanted to know what it sounded like, and had been mortified when her mother knocked on the wall.

"Kavanagh," Dr. Fenn said. "Line four hundred and fifty. She says she did it. Why does she say it in that order."

"Because she wants to be caught," said the girl called Perdita, before Nell could speak, and there was a small laugh round the table.

Dr. Fenn did not look at Perdita. She looked at Nell and waited, and the waiting had no impatience in it at all, and that was worse.

"No," Nell said.

The laugh stopped.

"She puts the god first and herself second," Nell said. "Zeus did not proclaim this. Then Justice. Then, only after that, the I. If she says I did it first, then the rest is her excusing herself, and she is a girl explaining. If she puts the law first, then the I at the end is not an admission, it is a signature." She had said more than she meant to. She kept going anyway. "It is the same trick you get in a confession that is really a claim. The order does the work. You can say the exact same words in the other order and it is a different speech."

Nobody said anything for what felt like a while and was probably three seconds.

"Yes," Dr. Fenn said.

She wrote something in the margin of her own text with a pencil.

"Nobody at this table has said that in six years," she said, to the room, not to Nell. "Ollerenshaw, you have read this play four times and you thought she wanted to be caught, which is what people think when they have read the introduction and not the play. Ashworth-Kane, your accent is improving and your grasp is not. Lindqvist, you have not spoken, which is your custom, and it is not humility, it is inventory."

The boy at the far end, Ivo, moved his pencil half an inch and did not look up.

"Fifteen hundred words on the order of the clauses in that speech, all of you, by Friday. Kavanagh, not you, you have already done it in the room, do me the Sophocles chorus instead, the one about man being terrible."

"The Ode on Man."

"Deinos," Dr. Fenn said. "Not terrible. Not wonderful. Both. English has no word and it is the only interesting fact about English." She stood. "Out. Not you, Kavanagh."

They went out slowly, in the way of people who want to be seen not to hurry. The tall boy, Ashworth-Kane, paused at the door and said, "Doctor Fenn, the Thursday reading," and she said, "Yes, as usual," and he said, "Only, with Kavanagh," and Dr. Fenn said, "That is not your business yet," pleasantly, and he went out.

Nell stood by the fire. When the door closed the room was very quiet and she could hear the coal.

"Sit down," Dr. Fenn said.

She sat down.

"Your personal statement was four hundred words long," Dr. Fenn said. "The word limit is a thousand. Why."

"Because I said what I had to say."

"Yes." Dr. Fenn was looking through a folder that Nell realised, with a lurch, was her own. Her form. Her predicted grades. The letter from Mrs. Aspinall at Kingsley Academy, which Nell had never read. "Do you know how many personal statements I read in November."

"No."

"Neither do I, after a point. They are all the same document. A student says that they are passionate about the ancient world, and that a teacher inspired them, and that literature teaches us empathy, which it does not, or Thucydides would have been a nicer man." She turned a page. "Yours said that you wanted to read Greek because you had been told twice by careers advisers that it was not for you, and you wanted to find out who had decided that and on what evidence."

Nell felt her face go hot.

"That was possibly not a good idea to put in a personal statement."

"It was an extremely bad idea to put in a personal statement," Dr. Fenn said. "It is why you are sitting in this room." She closed the folder. "You will find that the teaching here is better than what you have had and the students are not. Do not confuse the two. Half the children at that table have been coached since they were nine and can produce an essay that sounds like an answer. You cannot do that yet, and you must not learn."

"Right," Nell said.

"You will be behind in the Greek. That is arithmetic, not ability. Two hours a day, on top of everything, until March. You may use this room in the evenings, there is a fire in it, which the tower does not have." Dr. Fenn straightened the

papers again, though they were already straight. "The tower is very cold. I am sorry about that. It was not my decision where they put you."

"It's fine."

"It is not fine, it is January in Northumberland," Dr. Fenn said. "But it is the room that was free."

She said it without weight. She said it the way you say any true thing. And then she looked up, and for a second Nell had the disorienting sense of being examined by someone who had already read the whole of her, back to front, in advance, and who had been waiting some time for the person to catch up with the file.

"I knew it was you," Dr. Fenn said. "In November. As soon as I read it."

"Knew what was me?"

But Dr. Fenn had picked up her bag, and the moment closed like a hand.

"Two hours a day," she said. "Chorus by Friday. Shut the door behind you, it swells in the damp and if you do not pull it, it stands open all night and the fire goes out."

At the door Nell stopped, because there was a thing in the room she had been looking at for an hour without seeing it, and now that she had seen it she could not leave it alone.

On a side table by the window there was a typewriter.

It was a heavy old machine, black, with round keys, the sort of object that in Hull would have been in a charity shop window with a price on a bit of card. There was paper in it. There was a wooden chair drawn up to it at exactly the angle of a chair somebody uses.

"You may use that as well," Dr. Fenn said, without turning round. "The office will not print for students after five and the network here is a rumour. Everything of mine that matters has been written on it. You will find it takes a heavier touch than you expect and the ribbon needs changing and I never change it."

"People still use these."

"I still use this," Dr. Fenn said. "There is a difference, and it is the difference between a habit and a fashion." She put her folder into her bag and clipped the bag shut. "It is also the only machine in this building that nobody can read over your shoulder from another room, which mattered to me in 2007 and has mattered rather more since."

Nell touched one of the keys, lightly, not enough to strike.

"Go on," Dr. Fenn said. "It does not bite."

Nell pressed the letter e, and the arm came up and hit the paper with a crack that was much louder than she expected, and the letter printed high, sitting a half line above the others, like a person standing on tiptoe at the back of a photograph.

"It does that," Dr. Fenn said. "It has done that for eleven years. Bring me the chorus on Friday."

Nell pulled the door behind her, hard, the way she had been told, and heard it settle into the frame, and went down the stairs two at a time because she was late for Latin, and thought about the letter e for perhaps four seconds in total.

Sam

On the Thursday it snowed, thinly, and stopped, and by the afternoon the snow had gone everywhere except the north side of walls, where it stayed for the rest of the term.

Nell found Sam in the boot room at four, sitting on the bench with a book on his knees and one shoe off, and he looked up and said, "Good. You've got twenty minutes before dark, get your coat," as though they had arranged it.

"Where are we going."

"The village. There's a shop. It sells four things and one of them is decent chocolate and I'm going to introduce you to the person who runs it, because when you have been here eight weeks you will need somewhere to go that is not this, and it is important that the somewhere is a place where they know your name."

They went down the drive and out through the gates, which stood open and always had, and along the road under the beeches. Their breath went ahead of them. The moor on the left had turned the colour of a wet paper bag.

"Right," Sam said. "Ask me the questions. You've been storing them up for three days, I can see it happening behind your face."

"Is it that obvious."

"You've got a very loud face. It'll be a problem here. Go on."

"Why is there a scholarship in January."

He walked on four or five paces.

"That's your first question."

"That's my first question."

"Most people's first question is why is the food so good when the heating is so bad." He put his hands in his pockets. "There isn't a scholarship in January. That's

the thing. The Pemberton's a proper old endowment, there's a board of it in the hall, it goes back to the eighteen nineties. But it's awarded in March, for the September intake, and it's advertised in November, and it takes about four months because there's an exam and an interview and a second interview." He glanced at her. "You didn't do an exam."

"I did a paper. They sent it. I did it at school in the library with Mrs. Aspinall watching me and posted it back."

"In how long."

"Nine days."

"Nine days," Sam said. "Right."

"So what does that mean?"

"It means somebody wanted it done." He said it lightly. "Which is not sinister on its own. There's money in that endowment doing nothing, and Fenn's been at war with the bursar about it since before I got here, and if a place came free and Fenn saw a chance to prove her point with a body in the seat, she'd do it in nine days and enjoy it. She's like that. She wins arguments by making things true."

"A place came free."

"A place came free," Sam agreed.

They walked. A car went past and the driver lifted two fingers off the wheel and Sam lifted a hand back.

"Her name was Cassia Brandt," he said. "She was in the seminar. She was in my year. She left last January, in the middle of the winter term, family thing, and it was all very quiet and then it was the Easter holidays and then it was a new year, and here you are in her room."

"Margot said her name like it was a warning."

"Margot's French, everything she says sounds like a warning, it's the vowels." He smiled and the smile did something Nell would only recognise later, which was that it arrived slightly before the amusement did. "Ask the real question."

Nell stopped walking.

"How do you know the catch on the window in fourteen is broken?"

Sam stopped too, a step further on, and turned round, and for a moment the road was very quiet. There was a bird doing something small in the hedge.

"Because I sat on that windowsill about forty times last year," he said. "Because that room was where we all ended up, because it's the top of the tower and it's the furthest from anybody who cares what time it is. Because Cassia was my friend, and

she is the reason I know how to be in this place without going mad, and when she went I stopped going up those stairs, and then in December I heard they'd put a scholarship girl in her room and I thought that's grim, someone should go and talk to her." He shrugged. "So I did. That's all it is. It's not a mystery. It's just a school where everything is second hand, including the rooms."

It was a good answer. It was better than good. It was the kind of answer that closes a subject, and it made her feel small and rude for having asked, and it did the one thing that no innocent answer ever does, which was that it had been ready.

She did not see that then. She saw it in March.

"Sorry," she said.

"Don't be sorry. Be careful, though." He started walking again and she caught him up. "The five of them. Teddy, Margot, Ivo, Perry, and me, except I'm not really one of the five, I'm the one they invite so the photograph looks generous. They'll be nice to you. Teddy especially, and Teddy is very good at it."

"Why is that a warning."

"It isn't. It's a weather report." They came round the bend and there were houses, six of them, and a shop with a lit window and a rack of newspapers outside under a plastic cover. "Just, when you're the new person and everyone is being kind to you, ask yourself once a week what it costs them. If it costs them nothing, it's manners. If it costs them something, that's when it's worth knowing why they're paying."

The shop sold four things and one of them was decent chocolate. The woman behind the counter was called Bernie and she said, "Who's this then," and Sam said, "This is Nell, she's new, she's in the tower, she'll be in for the Dairy Milk every Thursday until March," and Bernie said, "Aye, they all are," and wrote something in a notebook that had nothing to do with anything.

There was a corkboard by the door with cards pinned to it, a man offering to lay gravel, a lost cat, a whist drive in the village hall on the second Tuesday of the month. Nell read them all while Sam counted coins, because reading things was what she did with her hands.

"You're up at the college, then," Bernie said.

"Yes."

"They send a lad down for the papers on a Sunday." Bernie put the chocolate in a paper bag, which nobody had done for Nell since primary school. "Mind, we had the police in here last winter, asking had anybody seen a lass on the road. January, it

were. Middle of the night, they said, and I says to them, if there'd been a lass walking that road at that time in that weather she'd not have got as far as my gate, and they thanked me very nicely and wrote it down and off they went."

The shop was very quiet. The fridge hummed.

"That's the road we just came up," Nell said.

"That's the only road there is, pet."

Sam had his back to them, putting his change into his pocket, and he took slightly longer over it than the operation required.

"Come on," he said. "It'll be dark on us."

Outside, Sam broke the chocolate in half without asking and gave her the bigger piece, which she noticed and did not comment on.

"Second piece of advice," he said. "Get a job."

"Here?"

"There's a list in the office. Library shelving, chapel flowers, kit room on match days. Two pounds an hour less than it should be and it takes four hours a week." He put his half in his pocket for later, which she also noticed. "Not for the money. Because when the others go into Newcastle on a Saturday and it costs forty quid by the time you've had lunch, you will need a reason that is not I cannot afford it. Nobody here has ever had to say that sentence out loud and you will find you would rather die."

"That's bleak."

"It is extremely bleak and it will save you about nine humiliating conversations a term." He blew on his hands. "Third piece. Say yes to things in the first six weeks even when you would rather read. After six weeks the shapes have set and you will be outside them for two years."

"How many pieces of advice are there?"

"Four," said Sam, "and the fourth one I am not giving you tonight."

Going back, in the dark, with the chocolate, Nell said: "What was she like?"

"Cassia?" Sam thought about it, or did the thing that looks like thinking. "She was the cleverest person here. Including the staff, and including Fenn, and Fenn knew it, which is the only reason Fenn liked her." A pause. "She was also a nightmare. She couldn't leave things alone. If she thought a thing was wrong she'd say so, in the room, in front of whoever it was, and then she'd be surprised that people minded."

"What kind of things."

"Small things," Sam said. "Always small things. That's what nobody understands about her. It was never anything big."

They came up the drive. The three lit windows were lit. Somewhere above them the clock in the tower made the click it made before the bell.

"Nell," Sam said, at the door, with his hand on it. "Do me a favour and don't repeat this conversation to any of them. Not because there's anything in it. Because Teddy will hear that I got to you first and he'll be irritated, and when Teddy is irritated he is charming at you for about a fortnight, and honestly, I'd rather spare you."

He held the door open for her.

Ten days later, when Teddy Ashworth-Kane crossed a room to shake her hand as if she were a visiting adult, Nell would remember that sentence, and would take it as evidence that Sam had told her the truth.

It was, in fact, the single most useful thing anyone said to her that term, and she understood it exactly backwards.

The Five

The invitation came in the form of a knock on the door of room fourteen at nine o'clock on a Saturday night, which was three hours after Nell had decided she was going to spend the evening with the Ode on Man and a hot water bottle.

Perdita Ollerenshaw was on the landing in a dressing gown over a dress, holding a bottle of gin by the neck the way you hold a chicken.

"We're upstairs," she said. "You're coming."

"Upstairs is my room."

"Not your stairs. The other stairs. Everyone thinks the tower stops at fourteen and it doesn't, there's a door behind the linen cupboard and it goes up to the clock loft, and it is the single warmest room in this entire freezing sarcophagus because the flue from the kitchens goes up through the wall of it, which is the one thing the eighteenth century got right." Perdita looked past her into the room, frankly, at the bed and the desk and the one lamp. "God, they haven't even given you a rug. Bring your quilt."

"Am I invited or am I being collected."

Perdita considered this with more seriousness than Nell expected.

"Collected," she said. "But nicely."

The clock loft was warm. That was the first shock. It was a low room under the roof with the clock mechanism behind a wooden housing at one end, turning and clicking to itself, and a bare bulb, and a nest of cushions and blankets on the boards, and a paraffin heater that Nell was fairly certain would have given the fire officer a stroke, and the four of them.

"Kavanagh," said the tall boy, and stood up.

He stood up. Nobody her own age had ever stood up when she came into a room. He came across the boards in his socks and put out his hand and shook hers, once, firmly, looking at her while he did it.

"Teddy Ashworth-Kane. I've been extremely rude and left it a week, and the reason is that Perry said if I came in the first week you'd think I was a creep, and Perry is usually right about people. Sit down. That corner's the warm one, the wall backs on to the flue. Perry, give her the good blanket."

"She can have the good blanket if she tells us something true," Perdita said, pouring gin into a mug with a broken handle.

"She can have the good blanket because it's minus two," said Margot, from the floor, without looking up from her book.

Ivo Lindqvist did not say anything. He was sitting under the bulb with a notebook open on his knee, writing, and when Nell sat down he raised two fingers off the page in greeting and went back to it.

It was, Nell thought afterwards, one of the best nights of her life, and she was aware of that even while it was happening, which was the strange part.

They were funny. That was the thing nobody warns you about. She had built them in her head out of the boards in the entrance hall and the gold names, and they turned out to be five nineteen year olds in a cold building doing impressions of the staff. Teddy did the bursar, a performance involving a great deal of throat clearing and the phrase in the current climate, and Perdita did Dr. Fenn saying deinos, and did it well enough that Nell laughed until her eyes ran, and Margot said, without heat, "That is not funny, that is cruel," and Perdita said, "It's both, darling, it's deinos," and even Margot laughed at that.

They asked her things. Real things, not tests. Teddy asked what her mother did and listened to the answer and asked a second question about it, which was the mark, Nell would learn, of the very well brought up and told you nothing whatever about whether they liked you. Perdita asked whether Hull was by the sea and was delighted to be told it was on an estuary, and made her explain the difference twice. Ivo asked, out of nowhere, what edition of the Antigone she had used, and when she said a paperback from a charity shop with a boy's name in it, he wrote something in the notebook.

"What are you writing?"

"The edition," Ivo said.

"Why?"

"He writes down everything," Perdita said. "Everything. It's a condition."

"It is not a condition," Ivo said.

"What did you have for breakfast on the ninth of November."

"Porridge, and the bacon was off, and you said so twice at the table and once in the corridor."

"See," said Perdita. "A condition."

Later, when the gin had gone round twice and Nell had drunk about a third of a mug of it because she had never really drunk anything and did not want the first time to be in a clock loft with strangers, the talk went quiet the way talk does after midnight, and Teddy lay back on the cushions with his arms behind his head and said, to the ceiling:

"You should know that we knew we were doing this. Coming to get you. It's not spontaneous."

"Teddy," said Margot.

"No, she should know, because she's clever and she'll work it out and then she'll think we were managing her." He turned his head to look at Nell. In the light of the one bulb his face was open and tired and about fourteen years old. "The five of us have been the five of us since we were thirteen, and this year it's been rotten, and we have been rotten to each other in the specific way that people are when they've run out of new things to say. And then in December we heard there was a scholarship girl coming in January, in the middle of the year, into that room, and every one of us thought the same thing separately, which is that it would be unspeakable to leave her sitting down there in the cold on her own."

"That is a very nice speech," Margot said.

"It is a nice speech, but it's also true, which is allowed."

"It's true," Perdita said, unexpectedly, into her mug. "It's true, actually."

Nell said, "Thank you," and meant it, and hated slightly how much she meant it.

It was the moment she remembered afterwards, and she remembered it as a warm room and a bare bulb and Teddy's socks with a hole in one heel. Everything she learned in the following ten weeks she had to lay over the top of it, like a card over a photograph, and it never lay flat.

At midnight Ivo got up and went out without saying anything, and came back eleven minutes later with his coat on and snow in his hair, and nobody asked him where he had been, and Nell understood that this too was a thing that happened regularly enough not to require asking.

"He walks," Perdita said, seeing her face. "Every night. Twice round the Quad and up to the chapel and back. He's done it since we were thirteen."

"In this?"

"Especially in this." Perdita drank. "You have to let people have their thing. Teddy has the being marvellous. Margot has the being French at people. Ivo has the walking, and the writing everything down, and I have this." She turned the mug so the broken handle showed. "We're all just about held together, darling. Nobody here is having a nice time. It only looks like it from underneath."

It was the single most useful sentence anybody said to Nell in her first month, and Perdita said it with her eyes half shut and did not remember it in the morning.

At half past one they went down. Margot came behind her on the stairs with the torch, because the landing light had gone and nobody had replaced it since the autumn, and at the turn of the stair Nell stopped to let her past with the torch and Margot put her hand flat on the wall to steady herself.

The torch was under her chin, pointing up. It lit her palm from beneath.

There was a scar across it. It ran from the base of the thumb to the far edge below the little finger, right across the pads at the base of the fingers, a straight clean line, pale and slightly raised, healed but not old.

Nell looked at it for about a second and a half, which was one second longer than she should have.

Margot took her hand off the wall.

"Glass," she said. "In the kitchens, at the end of the summer. I put my hand down on a broken jar in a sink of water. Fourteen stitches and the nurse said I was lucky, and I said, if I was lucky there would not have been a jar in the sink, and she wrote uncooperative in my notes."

"That sounds like you."

"It was a very stupid jar," Margot said.

She went down two steps and then stopped and turned round, and the torch was pointing at the floor now, and her face was in the dark above it.

"Nell. When they ask you about her, and they will, all of them, one at a time, because that is how they do things." A breath. "Just listen. Do not compare."

"Do not compare what?"

But Margot was already going down, and the light went with her, and Nell stood in the black on the sixty-first stair with her hand on the cold wall and no idea at all what she had just been given.

Five Versions

Margot was right about the method. They came one at a time.

Perdita came first, on the Monday, in the queue for lunch, cheerfully, as though she had been waiting for permission.

"You've seen the coat, then."

"I've seen the coat."

"I said. I said to Teddy, they can't put her in there with the wardrobe still full, and he said the office would deal with it, and the office has not dealt with it, because the office has not dealt with anything since 1994." Perdita took two rolls and put one in her pocket. "Ask me. Go on. Everybody wants to and nobody does and it's exhausting."

"What happened to her?"

"She left." Perdita said it easily. "The fourteenth of January. There was a thing with her family, and she went, and it was all very sudden, and then there was a letter from her about a fortnight later saying she was sorry and she was not coming back. Teddy's got it somewhere, or Ivo has."

"Did you see her go?"

"God, no. It was the middle of the night, or the early morning, or whenever. I was asleep. I sleep like the dead, ask anyone, I once slept through a fire drill in my own house."

"Who did see her go?"

"Ivo," Perdita said, "because Ivo was up. Ivo is always up. He was in the chapel doing the bell, and he says he saw the taxi on the drive."

Teddy came second, on the Tuesday, and did it properly, which is to say he made an occasion of it. He found her in the library and sat down opposite her and put his hands flat on the table.

"You'll have been asking about Cassia."

"People keep telling me about Cassia without my asking."

"Yes, they would." He said it wearily and it was the first time she had heard him sound like a person carrying something. "Right. Here it is, and then you can have it from me instead of in pieces. Her father was ill. It came on fast and it was bad, and there was a night in the middle of January when it went very wrong, and her mother rang the school at some ungodly hour, and Cassia went home that night. The school ordered the car. She never came back, and in the spring she wrote and withdrew formally, and that was that."

"You were friends."

"She was the best of us," Teddy said. "By a distance. And I do mean the best, not the cleverest, although she was that too."

"Perry said Ivo saw the car."

"Did she." A small pause, no longer than a breath. "Yes, that's right, Ivo was on the bell. I remember him telling me at breakfast that he'd seen it go down the drive with the lights on."

Ivo came third, or rather Nell went to him, on the Wednesday, in the chapel, where he was doing the eleven o'clock bell because it was his turn on the rota.

The chapel was freezing and smelled of paraffin and old hymn books. The rope hung down out of the dark of the tower with a worn leather grip on the end of it, and Ivo stood under it and pulled it in a slow steady rhythm, counting under his breath in Greek, which Nell decided not to ask about.

"I want to ask you about January," she said, when he had finished.

Ivo coiled the rope on its hook. He did it carefully, in even loops.

"Yes," he said.

"You saw the car."

"I saw the car."

"From here?"

"From here you cannot see the drive," Ivo said. "You can hear it. The gravel. I heard the gravel and I went to the door and I saw the tail lights at the gate."

"What time?"

"Twenty past eleven at night."

"You're sure."

"Yes," said Ivo, and there was no defensiveness in it at all, only the flatness of a person reading a measurement off a dial. "I am sure because I was ringing the eleven o'clock and it takes me eighteen minutes and I had just finished."

Margot came fourth, on the Thursday, and Margot did not come to tell her anything. Margot came to sit in her room with a book and be silent in company, which she did about twice a week that term, and it was Nell who broke it.

"Margot. The fourteenth of January."

"Yes."

"Where were you?"

"In our room," Margot said, to her book. "Asleep. She woke me getting her things and I said what is it and she said my father, and I said do you want me to come down with you and she said no. And I went back to sleep." She turned a page. "That is the part I would change. Everybody has one. That is mine."

"Margot," Nell said. "Can I ask one more?"

"You will ask it either way."

"When she woke you. Getting her things." Nell chose the words carefully, because she had been thinking about this one for two days. "What did she take?"

Margot did not look up from the book, but she stopped reading it. Nell could tell, because the eyes stopped moving.

"A bag," she said. "The canvas one."

"Not the trunk."

"You do not take a trunk at midnight."

"No," Nell said. "But you take your coat."

The room was quiet. Downstairs somebody was running a bath and the pipes were making the noise the pipes made, a long knocking, going up the wall.

"It was minus four that night," Nell said. "I looked it up. There's an archive, the Met Office publish it, you can get any night you like. Minus four with a wind. She went out of this building at midnight to go to her father, and she left a wool coat hanging six feet from where you are sitting."

Margot closed the book on her finger.

"You have been thinking about this a great deal," she said.

"I sleep in her room."

"Yes." Margot looked at the wardrobe. She looked at it the way a person looks at a thing they have trained themselves not to look at, which is to say directly, and for

slightly too long. "She had two coats. She had the green one, which was her grandmother's, and she had a horrible padded thing from a supermarket that she wore to walk in, and she was wearing that."

It was a good answer.

"All right," Nell said.

"It is not all right," said Margot, "but it is true," and she opened the book again, and that was the end of the evening.

Sam came fifth, and Sam came last, and Sam was the only one who noticed what she was doing.

She found him in the boot room on the Friday and asked him the same question she had asked the other four, in the same words, because by then she was being careful about the words.

"Where were you on the night of the fourteenth of January?"

He was lacing a boot. He finished the lace, and pulled it, and tied it.

"I was in my room," he said. "I heard the bell. I remember the bell because it was late, and because whoever was doing it was doing it badly, and I lay there and counted and thought, that is not eleven, that is not anything, and then I went to sleep."

Nell had a notebook by then. It was a cheap one from Bernie's shop with a picture of a Northumbrian coast on the front and it lived inside her Greek grammar with the laundry docket. That night she sat on the bed in her coat and wrote out the five accounts in five columns, the way Dr. Fenn made them lay out variant readings of a text, and looked at them for a long time.

Four of the five agreed on everything that mattered. The father, the night, the car, the letter. They agreed too well, in a way she could not put a finger on, the way that four people who have been in a room together agree.

But the fifth column was the bell.

Perdita said Ivo was ringing the bell.

Teddy said Ivo was ringing the bell.

Ivo said he was ringing the bell, and gave her the length of time it took him, and the exact minute he finished, which was the sort of detail a person supplies when they want to be believed and also, she thought, the sort of detail a person supplies when it is simply true.

Sam said he heard the bell and that whoever was ringing it was doing it badly.

And Ivo Lindqvist, who had been ringing that bell every fortnight for six years, who counted the strokes in Greek, did not do anything badly.

She wrote that at the bottom of the page and underlined it, and then, because it seemed such a small and stupid thing to have underlined, she wrote under that: it is always small things.

Then she sat looking at her own handwriting, in a cold room, at half past eleven at night, and remembered that it was Sam who had told her that.

The Letter

The office was open between nine and eleven and again between two and four, and was run by the woman in the grey cardigan, whose name turned out to be Mrs. Enderby, and who had worked at Ravensfell for twenty-six years.

Nell went in on a Tuesday afternoon with a reason that was true, which she had learned by then was better than a lie.

"I need my address changed on the file. My mother's moved."

It was true. Her mother had moved in December, from the flat above the bookmaker's to her sister's, because with Nell boarding there was no reason to keep two bedrooms she could not heat, and that fact sat in Nell's chest like a swallowed stone every time she looked at the radiator in the Fenn Room.

Mrs. Enderby found the file and made the change and pushed the form across for a signature, and Nell signed it, and then said, in the voice of a girl making conversation:

"Can I ask you something odd?"

"You can ask."

"My room. Fourteen. There's still somebody's things in the wardrobe and nobody will collect them and I don't know what I'm supposed to do. I don't want to put someone's coat in a bin bag."

Mrs. Enderby put down her pen.

"No," she said. "No, you shouldn't have to do that."

"It's been a year, apparently."

"It has been a year." Mrs. Enderby looked at the shelf of box files behind her, and it was the look of a woman being made to think about a thing she had put down

deliberately. "I wrote to them twice. In the March and again in the September. You do not chase a family a third time about a wardrobe."

"Did she leave in a hurry?"

"They said her father was taken ill."

They said. Nell put her hands in her lap so that they would not do anything.

"Is there anything on the file? Only, I keep being told different things by different people and I feel like an idiot asking them again."

Mrs. Enderby hesitated, and then did the thing that Nell would think about for a long time afterwards, which was that she got the file down.

"There's nothing confidential in a withdrawal," she said, mostly to herself. "It is a fact of the school. It is on the leavers' list in the library, for that matter, anybody can read that."

The file was thin. There was a photocopy of a passport page, and a fees record with the word BURSARY stamped across it in the same purple ink as the laundry docket, and a page of exam entries with a line drawn through it in biro, and, on top, a single sheet of paper in a plastic sleeve.

Mrs. Enderby turned it round so Nell could read it.

It was typed.

14 January

Dear Dr. Aldiss,

I am writing to confirm that I am withdrawing from Ravensfell College with immediate effect, for family reasons which I would rather not set out. I am sorry to do this in the middle of a term. I am grateful for what the school has given me and I do not want any fuss made.

Please do not send anyone to see us.

Yours sincerely,

And under that, a signature in blue ink, small and cramped, C. Brandt.

Nell read it twice. It took eleven seconds and it changed nothing at all, because it said what everybody had said, and it was signed, and it was dated the fourteenth.

"That's it?"

"That is generally it," Mrs. Enderby said. "People imagine leaving a school is a great ceremony. It is a letter and a form and somebody comes for the trunk."

"Nobody came for the trunk."

"No," said Mrs. Enderby. "Nobody came for the trunk."

Nell looked at the letter again, and something about it snagged, and she could not for the life of her say what. It was not the words. The words were exactly the words. It was something about the shape of it on the page, some small wrongness of the sort you get in a photograph where a picture on the wall behind is hanging crooked, and your eye keeps going back to it and you do not know why you are still looking at the photograph.

"Can I have a copy?"

"No," said Mrs. Enderby, kindly and immediately, and put the file back on the shelf, and that was the end of it.

"Mrs. Enderby," Nell said, at the door, "how long does it take? To get a girl out of a school."

Mrs. Enderby had gone back to her ledger. She did not look up, and she did not pretend not to have heard, and the pen kept moving for a line and a half before it stopped.

"There is a form," she said. "The form goes to the head, and the head signs it, and the bursar signs it, because of the fees. Then there is a letter to the family, and the family write back, and then I take the name off the lists. Register, dining, chapel rota, sanatorium, the insurance schedule. There are eleven lists." She put the pen down. "It takes a fortnight if everybody is quick. It usually takes a month."

"And with Cassia?"

"With that one," said Mrs. Enderby, "I had it all off the lists by the seventeenth."

"Of January."

"Of January."

She said it without any expression whatever, in the voice of a woman reporting a fact about stationery, and then she looked up at Nell, and held her eye for slightly longer than the sentence needed, and Nell understood that she had been given something on purpose, by a woman who would never in her life say a word against the school that had employed her for twenty-six years.

"Thank you," Nell said.

"Get your address changed on the chapel rota as well," Mrs. Enderby said. "They send the card to the home address at Easter and it will go to the wrong house."

Nell went out into the corridor and stood by the noticeboard with her heart going and made herself write down what she had read, word for word, into the cheap notebook, before it degraded, because she had learned that in the seminar:

you write it down before you interpret it, or you will find you have written down the interpretation.

Dear Dr. Aldiss. Immediate effect. Family reasons which I would rather not set out. I do not want any fuss made. Please do not send anyone to see us.

She looked at that last line for a while.

Then she wrote, in the margin: typed.

And under that, after a moment, because she was being honest with herself even when it made her feel stupid: everyone types.

She went up to the library and found the leavers' list, which was a printed sheet in a binder that recorded every departure since 1968, and BRANDT, C. was on it, with the date, 14/01, and under the column marked DESTINATION somebody had written a single word in biro.

Home.

Nell turned the pages of the binder backwards, because she had time and because she had begun, without noticing when it started, to check things she had no reason to check.

There were about nine leavers a year. Most had a school name in the destination column, or a town, or the word Sixth. Two in 2016 said Ill health. One in 2009 said, with no explanation whatsoever, Australia.

She went back through eleven years and found the word Home exactly three times, and the other two both had a second line under them in the same biro, giving a school, because a family that takes a child out in March puts that child in somewhere by September and the office writes it in when the request for a reference comes.

Under BRANDT, C. there was no second line.

Nobody had ever asked Ravensfell College for a reference for Cassia Brandt.

Nell sat with that for a while in the reading room, with the binder open on the table and the rain going down the tall window, and then she wrote it in the notebook, and it was the first time she wrote something down and felt frightened rather than clever.

Nell put the binder back and went down to the Fenn Room, because it was four o'clock and it was Tuesday and Tuesday was the chorus, and she worked for two hours in the one warm room in the building with the fire going and the clock ticking behind her, and at half past six she typed the fair copy of her translation on Dr. Fenn's machine, because the office would not print for students after five.

She typed slowly. She was not good at it. The keys needed a heavier touch than she expected and the ribbon was old and the letters came out grey and uneven, and every time she hit an e it printed high, a half line above the rest, so that the word deinos came out of the machine looking like this: dēinos, with the vowel lifted, standing on tiptoe at the back of the photograph.

She looked at that for a second. She thought, I will have to write these in by hand.

Then the bell went for supper, and she pulled the sheet out of the roller, and shut the door hard behind her the way she had been told, and went down to Hall, and thought about nothing at all except that she was hungry.

The Ice House

She started running at the end of January, for a reason that had nothing to do with any of it: the cold in room fourteen had got into her hands and she could not write for the first hour of every morning, and Sam said, without looking up, that the only cure for a cold building was to be warmer than it.

So she ran. Half past six, before the bell, out of the boot room door and round the back of the Old Quad and up the track that went behind the chapel and out onto the moor, and back down by the beeches, twenty minutes, in the dark at first and then, as February came, in a grey light that arrived a little earlier each week and never quite became morning.

On the fourth of February she went the wrong way at the top of the track.

It was not dramatic. The track forked, and she had always gone right because right went up, and that day her legs were dead and she went left because left was flat, and left curled round the shoulder of the hill behind the chapel and down into a hollow she had not known was there.

There was a building in it.

It was set into the slope, so that from three sides it was simply a grassed mound, and only from the front was it a building at all: a squat stone arch, half sunk, with a wooden door in it. Above the arch there was a date cut into the lintel, 1811, and a word, ICE.

Nell stood in the hollow in the frost with her hands on her knees and her breath going up in a column and looked at the door for perhaps a minute.

Then she went and looked at it properly, because she was that sort of person, and because she had thought at first that it was derelict, and it was not derelict.

The door was old. The frame was old. The hinges were old, and had been painted a great many times, and were furred with rust in the way of iron that has been out in Northumberland weather since before anyone alive was born. There was a hasp and staple screwed into the frame, and that was old too, and the screw heads were half eaten.

And through the hasp there was a chain, and the chain was old.

The padlock was new.

It was not new in the way that a thing is newer than the things around it. It was new. It was a brass and steel padlock of the kind sold in every hardware shop in England, and it was clean, and its shackle was bright, and where the rain had got at the chain and left it scaled with rust the lock had a film of grease on it that was still doing its job. It had not been out in more than a couple of winters. Perhaps one.

Nell put her hand on it. It was so cold it hurt.

She turned it over. On the back, stamped in the metal, there was a maker's name and, under that, a five digit number, and she stood in the frost and copied that number onto the inside of her wrist with a biro she had in the pocket of her running things because she was always writing things on herself.

The keyhole had no dust in it.

She tried the door, because there was no sense in not trying it.

It did not move at all, which she had expected, but the way it did not move told her something she had not expected. A neglected door in a wall gives a little. The frame swells, the hinges drop, and the whole thing sits loose in its opening and rattles in a wind. This one had been packed. There was a wedge of new timber driven in at the foot on the hinge side, squared off with a saw, and the gap along the top had been filled with something that had gone hard.

Somebody had not simply locked this building. Somebody had made it stop moving.

Nell crouched down and looked at the wedge for a long moment with her hands going numb, and then she got out her phone and took four photographs, which came out badly because there was no light, and one of them, the one of the lock with the number on the back of it, came out clearly enough to read.

She walked back up out of the hollow instead of running, and at the top of the rise she turned round and looked down at it, and the thing that struck her was how completely you could miss it. From the chapel path it was a bank of dead bracken. From the moor it was a mound. There were three hundred acres up here and eleven

of them were mowed for cricket and the rest was this: hollows and mounds and buildings that had gone back into the ground.

At breakfast she said, to the table generally, in the voice of a girl making conversation:

"There's an ice house behind the chapel."

The thing that happened then was not silence. That was what she understood afterwards, and it was the reason she did not understand it at the time. Nothing dramatic happened. Perdita said, "Is there?" with her mouth full. Teddy said that there were about four of those on the estate and that one of them had a bat colony in it and was a whole legal thing with the council. Ivo did not look up.

And Margot, who was buttering toast, went on buttering toast, and said, "They are all locked. The insurance."

"That one's got a new lock on it."

"They will have all been done at once," Margot said. "There was a man here in the summer doing the locks. He did the pavilion and the boiler house."

She put the knife down and picked up her tea, and her hand was perfectly steady, and she looked across the table at Nell with an expression of ordinary morning boredom.

It was a good answer. It was as good as Sam's answer about the window catch, and it had the same quality, and this time Nell noticed the quality, because she had now heard it twice.

It was ready.

Nell finished her toast. That was the part she was proudest of afterwards, and the part that frightened her most when she thought about what she was becoming: she sat at a table with five people she had begun to love and she finished her toast and she said something dull about the Latin set text, and Teddy answered, and the table moved on.

She had learned it from them. That was the truth of it. She had watched five people do it to her for a month and she had picked it up the way you pick up an accent.

She went to the eleven o'clock and to Latin and to Greek and to games, and all day she carried it around, and at four in the afternoon, in the last of the light, she did the thing she had been building towards without admitting it since breakfast, and went down to the boiler house behind the kitchens.

The boiler house had a hasp and a chain and a padlock.

The padlock was old. Green with it. The shackle had a groove worn in it where the chain had rubbed for years.

She went round to the pavilion, which took eleven minutes, out past the frozen pitches with her coat collar up. The pavilion padlock was old too, and someone had oiled it, at some point, badly, and the oil had gone to a black gum on the plate.

Nell stood on the steps of the cricket pavilion in the dark at ten past five in February and understood two things in the same second, and they arrived so close together that afterwards she could never separate them.

The first was that Margot had lied to her, at breakfast, easily, without a flicker, about a padlock.

The second was worse, and it went through her like cold water, and she had to sit down on the pavilion steps with her hands in her armpits.

They had all answered.

Every single one of them, from her first week: Sam on the road with his history of the Pemberton, Teddy in the library with the whole account laid out end to end, Ivo with the exact minute, Perdita in the lunch queue saying ask me, go on, everybody wants to and nobody does. Margot at breakfast with the man who came in the summer.

She had not had to prise a single thing out of anybody.

She had arrived in a school full of people who had known each other for six years, an outsider, a scholarship girl from Hull in a dead girl's room, and not one of them had told her to mind her own business. They had brought her up to the warm room. They had given her the good blanket.

She thought: they are not keeping me out.

She thought, sitting on the steps with the moor going black in front of her and the three lit windows behind her: they are letting me in.

And then, because she had been well taught by a woman who had told her that the order of the clauses does the work, she made herself finish the sentence properly, in the right order, with the I at the end where it belonged.

Somebody decided that a girl who asks questions should be here.

Somebody sent for me.

Lantern Night

Lantern Night was on the last Friday of February and Nell heard about it eleven times before anybody told her what it was.

It was the sort of thing Ravensfell did constantly: a word everyone used and nobody explained, so that being new was not a matter of not knowing things but of not knowing that you did not know them. She had a page at the back of the cheap notebook headed WORDS and it had thirty entries on it by half term. Hall. Rota. The Long. Sixes. Bumps. Deinos, which was Fenn's and did not count. Lantern Night.

"It's nothing," Perdita said. "It's a fire and a lot of singing and the head does a speech about the founder and then everyone gets drunk in a field."

"It is not nothing," said Ivo.

"It's a bit nothing."

"It is the oldest thing here," Ivo said. "It is older than the chapel. There was a Lantern Night before there was a school. It was the miners, and before the miners the farms, and it is the night in the year when the day gets longer than the night by an amount you can see." He was not looking at either of them. He was writing. "It is not about the founder. They put the founder in it in 1904."

"He does this," Perdita said to Nell, delighted. "He does this about everything."

What it was, in practice, was this: at six o'clock on the last Friday in February the whole school walked out of the Old Quad and up the track behind the chapel and onto the moor, in a line, each person carrying a lantern, which was a real lantern with a real candle in it and not a torch, because there had been an argument about this in the nineteen eighties and the traditionalists had won. At the top there was a bonfire that the groundsmen had spent three days building. The head gave a short

speech. Everybody sang two things, one of which was in Latin and one of which was not. Then the fire was lit, and after that the formal part was over, and what happened next was not organised by anybody and had been happening for two hundred years.

Nell walked up with Margot on one side and Perdita on the other and her lantern in her hand and the ice of the track under her boots, and behind her a hundred and forty people strung out down the hill in a line of small lights, and it was, without any qualification at all, the most beautiful thing she had ever seen.

"You are crying," Margot observed.

"It's the cold."

"It is not the cold."

"It's the cold," said Nell, and Margot, who was capable of great mercy at unpredictable moments, let it go.

At the top the wind came at them across three hundred acres of open moor and everybody turned their backs to it at the same instant, which was funny, and the head made his speech into it, and nobody heard a word, which everybody seemed to feel was traditional. Then they sang. Nell did not know either song and stood there mouthing, and Teddy leaned over halfway through the second one and said, in her ear, over the noise:

"Nobody knows the second verse. Nobody has ever known the second verse. Just make a noise like an oo."

She made a noise like an oo. It worked.

The fire went up so fast it made people step back, and there was a noise from the whole school that was not a cheer, more of an ah, the sound people make at fireworks, and then the formal part was over.

What happened next was that Ravensfell College, an institution of extreme seriousness with names in gold on its walls, turned for about four hours into a village fair. Somebody had a speaker. Somebody had brought a football and there was a game in the dark with the fire for a floodlight and no rules of any kind. Three girls in the year below were selling flapjack, illegally, for charity, from a rucksack. A geography teacher who had seemed to Nell a completely closed man stood on the edge of the light and let two thirteen year olds beat him at some game involving a stick, twice, on purpose, badly acted.

The five of them and Nell got the good spot, which was on the lee side of a wall about forty feet from the fire, where you got the heat and not the smoke, and which

Teddy had claimed at half five by leaving his coat on it, and which nobody had challenged, and which told Nell something about Teddy she filed away and did not examine.

They stayed there for three hours.

She would think about those three hours for the rest of her life.

Perdita did impressions until she cried and then did the impression of herself crying. Sam and Teddy conducted an argument about whether it was worse to be bad at something you love or good at something you hate, which went on for forty minutes and was, Nell realised late, the most serious conversation she had ever heard between two boys, conducted entirely in the register of a joke. Ivo passed round a flask of something his father sent him from Sweden that tasted of caraway and made Perdita say a word Nell had not heard a girl say out loud before. Margot lay on her back on the frozen ground with her coat under her and looked at the sky and did not talk to anyone, and at one point put her hand up, without looking, and Nell realised after a moment that it was to be pulled up, and pulled her up, and Margot said thank you in French and did not seem to notice she had.

At some point Teddy stood on the wall and made a speech about Nell.

"It has been," he said, "six weeks, and I want it minuted that in six weeks she has learned the entire Greek supplementary paper, beaten Ollerenshaw at cards, called the bursar a fraud to his face."

"I did not."

"You said his figures did not reconcile, which from you is the same thing, and he knew it. Six weeks. And she has done all this while sleeping in the coldest room in the north of England with a window that opens itself." He raised the flask. "To Kavanagh, who came in January."

"To Kavanagh," they said, and Perdita whooped, and Ivo tipped his head, and Sam smiled at her across the fire with his whole face.

And Margot said, "To Nell," which was different, and quieter, and Nell heard it.

There was one moment that she took out and looked at many times afterwards, and it lasted about forty seconds and nobody else at that fire would have remembered it at all.

Margot had gone to get more wood for the small fire they had made on their own side of the wall, and Nell had gone with her, and they had walked out to the stack together beyond the light, and it was very dark and very cold and the noise of the party came across the grass behind them, flattened by the wind.

Margot stopped with an armful of wood and looked back at it.

"They are all going to be fine," she said.

"What?"

"Teddy will be fine. He will read law and he will be fine. Perdita will be fine, she will marry somebody with a house and be extremely funny at parties for forty years and never once do the thing she is actually good at. Ivo will be fine, he will go to Uppsala and translate something nobody reads and be perfectly happy." She shifted the wood. "It is the strangest thing to know about people at eighteen. I can see the whole of it from here."

"And you?"

"I do not come into it," Margot said, and started back toward the fire.

Nell followed her with an armful of wood and asked nothing else, because she had known Margot Renard for five weeks and had already learned that you did not, and it was four days short of two months before she understood that she had just been told the entire truth of that term standing next to a wood stack in the dark.

At half eleven the teachers began the slow business of moving a hundred and forty people down a hill in the dark, and the line formed again, and the lanterns had mostly gone out and it was torches now, and the fire behind them was a red pit that two groundsmen would sit up with until three.

Nell walked down at the back with Sam.

"Was it what you expected?" he said.

"No."

"No. It never is." He kicked a stone off the track. "That's the trap, by the way. I'll say it once and then I'll shut up about it. Tonight is the trap."

"That's a horrible thing to say."

"It is, and I'm still saying it, because someone said it to me in my first year and I was furious and it was the most useful thing anybody ever did for me." He stopped walking, so she stopped too, and the line of lights went on past them down the hill. "This place is very good at three or four nights a year. It spends the other three hundred and sixty on people like you and me deciding whether we can afford to go home at Easter. Tonight is real. It is also the thing they will point at when they want something from you. Both of those are true at the same time and you have to be able to hold them both, or it eats you."

"Who wanted something from you?"

Sam looked down the hill at the lights.

"Everyone always wants something," he said. "That's not a complaint, it's just the weather. The question is only ever whether they tell you what it is."

He started walking again.

"Sam," Nell said. "What do you want from me?"

She had not planned to ask it. It came out of her, on a hillside, in the dark, at the end of the happiest night of her life, and she heard how it sounded and could not take it back.

Sam did not break stride, and he did not laugh it off, and he did not answer for eleven or twelve seconds, which is a very long time on a dark path.

"That's the right question," he said at last. "Keep asking people that. Ask Teddy that."

"I'm asking you."

"I know," said Sam. "I heard."

And then they came down onto the gravel where the light from the windows reached, and Perdita was waiting for them with two lanterns and something to say, and the moment was gone, and Nell put it in the notebook that night under the heading of things that had not been answered, where by then there were nine entries.

Ivo's Notebook

The notebooks were black, hardbacked, the same in every year, and Ivo bought them four at a time from a shop in Hexham. Nell knew this because he had told her, at length, on the walk down from the fire, with the specificity of a man discussing the only thing he collects.

"Why do you do it?" she had asked.

"Because I do not remember well."

"Ivo, you remembered what Perry had for breakfast in November."

"I remembered because I wrote it down," Ivo said, as though she had failed to follow a simple argument. "That is the whole point. I do not remember. I have a record. They are different things and people confuse them constantly."

She saw the inside of one on the first Monday of March, and it was an accident, and she wished for years afterwards that it had not been.

They were in the Fenn Room, the four of them who did Greek, working through a passage in the hour before supper with the fire down to its last red and the lamp on. Ivo had two notebooks out, the current one and an older one with a rubber band round it, and he was checking something between them. Then Perdita put her head round the door and said the words fish pie in a tone of high tragedy, and Ivo, who was hungrier than he was careful, got up and went to argue with her about it in the corridor, and left both books open on the table.

Nell did not go and look. She was already sitting next to them.

The current notebook was a list of dates down the left margin with entries beside them, some a line long, some four. 26 FEB, lantern, cold, wind NW, T made a speech. 27 FEB, no run, ice. She could see her own initial in it twice on that page

and had to sit with the strangeness of that for a second, of being an entry in another person's system.

The older notebook was open at a page from a January.

The pages went 11 JAN, 12 JAN, 13 JAN in a small, square, extremely regular hand, the same hand for weeks in every direction, a hand that never varied because the person had trained it not to.

Then 14 JAN.

Then, underneath, after four lines of entry, another heading: 14 JAN again.

The second one was in the same hand, and it was not.

Nell had spent five weeks in a seminar where a woman with a pencil taught six teenagers to look at a text and say what was in front of them rather than what they expected, and she looked at the two headings for perhaps four seconds and saw it the way you see a face in a pattern.

The first 14 JAN was written at the speed of every other date on the page. The pen had gone down, made the numeral, lifted, made the letters, all at one rhythm.

The second 14 JAN had been written slowly. It was the same shapes. It was a very good copy of the same shapes. But the strokes had that faint tremor that comes into handwriting when a person is concentrating on the writing itself instead of on the words, the tremor of a signature copied off a card, and the ink sat differently, and the letters were very slightly too even, and the whole thing was, in the exact sense of the word, a forgery of his own hand.

Under the first heading, four lines of the ordinary sediment of Ivo's life. Bell, 11pm, 18 min. Wind rising. Argument in the loft, T and C, did not stay. M went down after her.

Under the second heading, one line.

Bell 11pm. Quiet night. C left for home, family, car at 11.20, saw tail lights from chapel door.

Nell was aware of her own pulse in her ears and of the fire and of the corridor outside, where Perdita was saying something about fish and Ivo was answering her with genuine passion.

She did not touch either book. That mattered later, and she was glad of it.

She read the first entry four times, so that she would have it exactly, and then she took out her own notebook and wrote it down word for word before she interpreted it, because that was the rule.

Argument in the loft, T and C, did not stay. M went down after her.

The door opened. Ivo came back in, still mid sentence about the fish pie, and Nell was looking at her Greek text with her pencil in her hand, and she said, "It's fish pie," in a voice that came out perfectly normal, and Ivo said, "It is Monday, it is always fish pie, she does this every week," and sat down, and reached across, and closed the older notebook without any particular urgency, and put the rubber band back round it.

Then he stopped.

He did not look at her. He looked at the notebook under his own hand, and his hand was flat on the cover, and he stayed like that for about two seconds.

"Ivo," Nell said.

"The passage is four hundred and forty to four hundred and seventy," Ivo said. "Fenn will ask you for the anapaests and she will pretend it is a small question."

"Ivo."

He put the older notebook into his bag. He did it slowly and carefully, the way he coiled the bell rope, and he pushed the bag under the table with his foot, and then at last he looked up at her, and his face was completely white, and he was nineteen years old.

"I would like you to ask me in a week," he said.

"What?"

"Whatever you are going to ask me. I am not saying do not ask. I am asking you to ask me in a week." His voice was very level and his hands were not. "There is a thing I have to do first and if you ask me tonight I will lie to you, and I have found that I am no longer able to do that and then sleep, and I have to sleep, because I have the Cambridge papers on Thursday and my father has not asked me about anything else since October."

Nell sat with her pencil in her hand.

Everything in her wanted to push. She was six weeks into a school where she had learned that being clever was the only currency she had, and here was a boy with white knuckles asking her to wait a week, and she knew with total clarity that if she pushed him now she would get it, all of it, tonight, in this room.

She thought about Margot on the stairs saying just listen.

"All right," she said.

Ivo's shoulders came down about an inch.

"Thank you."

"A week today. Here."

"Not here," Ivo said. "Here has a fire, so it has people. The chapel. I do the eleven on Wednesday."

He picked up his pen and found his place in the Greek and translated eleven lines of it out loud without a single mistake, and Nell wrote her notes, and neither of them said anything else that mattered, and when Fenn came in at half past she remarked that they were the only two people in the school who had ever done the anapaests properly and that this was depressing.

That night Nell lay in room fourteen with the window shut and the wind doing what it did, and she took out the notebook and looked at what she had copied.

She worked on it for an hour, the way Fenn had taught her to work on a corrupt line: you do not ask what it should say, you ask what is actually there and what would have to be true for it to be there.

Two entries for one day. Both in his hand. One of them written at his ordinary speed, one of them drawn.

She turned it over three ways.

He had written the first entry on the night itself or the morning after, in the ordinary way, because that was what he did every day of his life. Then, at some point afterwards, days or weeks, he had written a second version and made it look like the first. He had not torn the page out. He had not crossed the first one through. He had left both, on the same page, one under the other, where anybody who ever opened that notebook would see them.

A forger who does not remove the original is not forging. He is making a copy and keeping the accounts.

She wrote that down and looked at it and felt something turn over in her chest, because it changed the shape of Ivo Lindqvist entirely. She had been carrying him around for two months as the quiet one, the inventory, the boy who wrote down what Perry had for breakfast. And this was not the act of a boy covering something up.

It was the act of a boy leaving evidence for himself, so that whatever he was made to say out loud, there would exist, in a notebook with a rubber band round it, a page on which the true thing and the false thing sat one above the other and could be compared by anyone who ever looked.

He had been keeping it for fourteen months.

And on the second of March he had put both notebooks on a table in a warm room, and gone out into the corridor to have an argument about fish pie with the

door open, and left them there, in front of the only person in the building who read for a living.

Nell put her pencil down.

She did not know, that night, whether that had been an accident. She spent a long time not knowing. In the end it was one of the two or three things about that whole term that she was never able to decide, and Ivo, who told her the truth about everything else, would never once be drawn on it.

She turned back to the four words she could not make fit into any version of the fourteenth of January that anybody had told her.

M went down after her.

Down where.

The Machine

She could not ask Ivo for a week. She had said so and she meant it, and it left her with seven days and a sentence she could not put down.

M went down after her.

Nell did what she had done since she was fourteen, which was to make a list, because a list was a way of being frightened in an orderly fashion. She sat in the Fenn Room on the Tuesday evening with the fire banked and wrote out everything she had, in the order she had got it, with the source beside each one, and looked at it, and it was the first time she had seen the whole shape at once.

Laundry docket, 15 Jan, room 14. Physical. In my grammar.
Coat left behind. Physical. In the wardrobe.
Photograph, five people, back says six. Physical. In the box.
Police on the road in January, asking about a girl walking. Bernie, village shop.
Pemberton advertised nine days, awarded in a fortnight. Sam.
Padlock on the ice house, new, greased. Physical. I have the number.
Boiler house and pavilion padlocks, old. Physical. Checked both.
Margot said all the locks were done in summer. Margot. False.
Bell rung badly on the 14th. Sam.
Bell rung by Ivo, 18 minutes, finished 11.20. Ivo, Teddy, Perdita.
Withdrawal letter, typed, signed, dated 14 Jan. Read it in the office.
Off the school lists by the 17th. Mrs. Enderby.
Argument in the loft, T and C. Ivo's notebook, first entry.
M went down after her. Ivo's notebook, first entry.
Second version of the same day, in his own hand, copied. Ivo's notebook.

She looked at the list for a long time and then wrote at the bottom: everything that is physical says she was here after the 14th. Everything that is a person says she left on the 14th.

And under that: the letter is a person or a thing?

It took her until Wednesday to understand her own question.

A letter is a thing. It exists, it is in a plastic sleeve in a box file on the second shelf of the office, and it can be examined. But a letter is also a statement by a person, and she had read it as a statement, and she had come away with the words instead of the object.

She had asked herself, at the noticeboard, what was wrong with the shape of it on the page. She had written the word typed in her own margin and then written under it, everyone types, and had put it down.

It came to her on the Wednesday afternoon in the middle of a hockey match, standing on a frozen pitch in a bib with her stick on the ground, so completely that she did not hear the whistle and got shouted at.

Everyone types. Nobody types.

She had spent six weeks in this school. She had watched a hundred and forty people do their work. Every essay she had ever seen handed in at Ravensfell was either handwritten in a bound exercise book, because half the staff insisted on it, or printed off the two machines in the library annexe, which jammed, and which had a sign on them saying NO STUDENT PRINTING AFTER 5PM in Mrs. Enderby's capitals.

There was, as far as she knew, exactly one typewriter in the building.

Nell got through the rest of the match on autopilot, went to Hall, ate nothing, and was at the door of the Fenn Room at ten past seven with her Greek under her arm and her heart going like a bird in a box.

The room was empty. The fire was in. She put the Greek down on the table and did not open it.

The typewriter sat on the side table by the window with a chair drawn up to it at the angle of a chair somebody uses.

She wound in a sheet of the school paper from the stack and typed one line.

Dear Dr. Aldiss,

She looked at it under the lamp.

The e in Dear stood a half line high. So did the e in Aldiss. The capital D was slightly filled in at the bowl, and the comma sat low, and the whole line had that grey unevenness of a ribbon that has not been changed for eleven years.

Nell closed her eyes and tried to see the letter in the office, and could not, not properly, because she had read it for what it said. She had a photographic memory for nothing at all. She could remember reading it, she could remember the plastic sleeve, and she could remember that something about the look of the page had snagged her eye and would not say why.

She typed the rest of it from her own notebook, all of it, the whole letter, word for word as she had copied it down at the noticeboard.

I am writing to confirm that I am withdrawing from Ravensfell College with immediate effect, for family reasons which I would rather not set out.

Please do not send anyone to see us.

Then she pulled the sheet out and held it under the lamp and looked at a letter of withdrawal from Ravensfell College, dated the fourteenth of January, typed on the machine in Dr. Aurelia Fenn's room, and it looked exactly like the one she had read.

It also looked exactly like every other thing that had ever come out of that machine, which was the problem, and she made herself say it out loud in the empty room because saying it out loud was the only way she had found to stop herself believing what she wanted to believe.

"That proves nothing. Any typewriter of that age does that."

It was true. She knew it was true. A high e is not a fingerprint. There were probably four hundred machines in England with a high e.

But there were not four hundred machines in this building.

There was a second thing, and it had been sitting in her notebook for six weeks with a line under it, and she got it out and looked at it now with the sheet still warm in her hand.

Please do not send anyone to see us.

She had copied that down at the noticeboard because it had struck her as a strange line, and had never worked out why, and now, standing over a typewriter at half past seven at night, she did.

It was the only sentence in the letter that did any work.

Everything else in it was the sort of thing a leaving letter says. Withdrawing with immediate effect. Family reasons I would rather not set out. Grateful for what the school has given me. Any of that could have come out of any pen in England.

But please do not send anyone to see us is not a sentiment. It is an instruction, and it has one effect and only one, which is that nobody from Ravensfell College ever knocks on the Brandts' door.

Nell put the two sheets side by side under the lamp, her own and her copy of theirs, and read the letter as an object rather than as a voice, and it came apart into its parts like a sentence being parsed.

A	date,	which	fixed	the	night.
A	signature,	which	made	it	hers.

And one line, which kept the school and the family from ever standing in the same room.

Whoever wrote it had needed all three, and had known they needed all three, and had done it in a single short paragraph on the night itself or the morning after, and had done it well enough that a school office had taken a girl off eleven lists by the seventeenth without anybody once picking up a telephone.

That was not a frightened teenager at midnight.

She was still standing there with the sheet in her hand when the door opened.

"You are in early," said Dr. Fenn.

Nell put the paper down on the table, face up, because face down would have been an admission, and because she had learned in six weeks that the safest place for a thing is exactly where it would be if it were innocent.

"I wanted the fire," she said.

"Yes." Dr. Fenn came in and set her bag on the chair and looked, without any particular interest, at the sheet on the table. She looked at it for two seconds. Then she looked at Nell, and the interest arrived.

"Practising," she said.

"The ribbon's grey."

"The ribbon has been grey since 2015 and I have said I will change it every year since." Dr. Fenn sat down. She did not take her coat off. "Kavanagh. You have been in this room every evening for five weeks and this is the first time you have looked frightened in it."

"I'm not frightened."

"No," Dr. Fenn agreed. "You are something else and you have not got the word yet. That will be the interesting part."

She reached over and turned the sheet round with one finger and read it, from the top, all the way down, and Nell stood absolutely still with her hands behind her back and made herself breathe.

Dr. Fenn read a letter of withdrawal from Ravensfell College in the handwriting of a machine she had owned for eleven years.

Then she turned it back round, exactly as it had been, and said:

"Your spacing after the comma is inconsistent. If you are going to use it, use it properly. There is a whole discipline to a machine like that and it is worth learning, because it will teach you that a document is an object and not a sentiment." She opened her bag and took out the folder. "Page four hundred and forty. The anapaests."

They did the anapaests for fifty minutes.

At the end of it, packing up, with her coat on and her hand on the door, Dr. Fenn said, without turning round:

"You may use the machine whenever you like. But you should know that everything that comes out of it looks the same, which cuts in both directions, and a clever person notices only the direction that suits her."

And she went out and left the door standing open, so that the fire went out in the night.

Perdita

Perdita Ollerenshaw drank on Fridays and on the last day of anything, and on the Friday of that week she drank in room fourteen, which she had not done before, and which Nell understood by the third glass was not an accident either.

She arrived at nine with the gin and a bag of ice she had stolen from the kitchens and a bottle of tonic that had gone flat, and she sat on the floor with her back against the wardrobe, which Nell could not have done, and started talking, and did not stop for two hours.

She talked about her mother, who was an actress of the kind that is recognised in Waitrose and not in the street, and who had put Perdita into Ravensfell at thirteen because a friend said it was the making of children, and who telephoned on Sundays and asked three questions in a row without waiting for the answers. She talked about her sister, who was better than her at everything. She talked about the school play, which she had been in every year since she arrived and had never once been given the part she wanted, and she did four minutes of a monologue she had learned for an audition in the autumn and had not been allowed to finish, and she did it well, standing up, in a cold room, with a mug in her hand, and Nell had the disorienting experience of watching someone she thought of as a joke turn out to have been telling the truth about herself all along in the only register she had.

"That was good," Nell said.

"It was quite good."

"No, it was good."

"Yes," said Perdita. "It was." She sat down again, hard, and put her head back against the wardrobe door. "That's the worst bit. If I were bad at it I could stop."

By eleven she had gone quiet and slow, and was pouring gin with the unhurried precision of the practised, and had begun the descending part of the evening, and Nell, who had drunk one glass in two hours and had spent the second hour of those two hours deciding whether to do this, put her mug down and said:

"Perry. Can I ask you about her?"

"Cassia."

"Yes."

"Everyone always wants to talk about Cassia." Perdita said it without any resentment at all, dreamily, to the ceiling. "She was so awful, actually. Nobody says that. She was completely awful and I loved her and she made everything an argument. You could not say a thing at a table without her wanting to know what you meant by it. Exhausting. Absolutely exhausting person. And then she would be, you know. Right." She drank. "She was the only one of us who was ever right about anything and it made her impossible to be in a room with."

"Right about what?"

"Everything. She was right about the play. She said the reason I never get the part is that they cast on confidence and I do confidence badly because I do it too loud, and she was right, and I did not speak to her for nine days." Perdita laughed. "Nine days. God. Nine days out of the number we had, and I spent them not speaking to her because she told me the truth about my own face."

"Perry."

"Mm."

"What happened the night she left?"

"She left," Perdita said.

"But what happened."

"She left, darling, that's the whole of it, that's what leaving is. She left and it was the middle of the night and I was asleep. I sleep like the dead. I told you. Ask anyone."

"You've told me that four times."

"Because it's true four times."

Perdita's eyes were shut. She had the mug balanced on her knee and her hand loose round it, and the room was cold and the wind was doing its thing at the window, and Nell sat six feet away on the floorboards with her back against the bed and made herself wait.

Forty seconds. A minute. The pipes knocked somewhere below.

"Perry," Nell said. "How many times have you told somebody you sleep like the dead?"

"What?"

"It's a thing you say. You said it to me on the second of February in the lunch queue, and again on the ninth in Hall, and again just now. Ask anyone. I sleep like the dead."

"Because I do."

"I know you do. I've heard you snoring through a wall." Nell kept her voice completely flat, because she had watched Fenn do this in a seminar for nine weeks and it was the only technique she had. "It's true. That's what's interesting about it. It's the only sentence in this entire school that everyone repeats and that also happens to be true."

Perdita's eyes were shut and she was smiling, and the smile went slowly away, like something being carried off.

"That is a horrible thing to notice," she said.

"I know."

"You are a horrible girl and I am extremely fond of you."

"I know that as well."

"She shouldn't have gone down," Perdita said.

Nell did not move.

"We told her not to. I told her. I said, leave it, Cass, leave it until the morning, everyone is drunk and everyone is horrible and nothing that gets said tonight is going to be true in the morning. And she said." Perdita's mouth moved, and something crossed her face that had nothing performed in it whatsoever. "She said, I have left it since November."

The wind. The pipes.

"Down where?" Nell said.

Perdita opened her eyes.

It was not a slow surfacing. It was instant, and complete, and Nell watched two hours of gin get overridden in a second and a half by something much stronger, and understood that whatever else Perdita Ollerenshaw was, she was not stupid, and had never been stupid, and had been performing something for six years in front of an audience that had stopped checking.

"Down the stairs," Perdita said. "To the yard. She was going out to the car and I said don't go tonight, go in the morning, it's minus four and you're upset and you'll drive off a road."

"She didn't drive. The school ordered the car."

"Then that is what I said to the school," said Perdita, "and one of us is drunk and it is not you, and I want my bed."

She got up. She got up perfectly steadily, which was the most frightening thing that had happened to Nell since she arrived, and she picked up the gin bottle by the neck and put the mug on the desk and stopped at the door.

"Nell."

"Yes."

"You are the best thing that has happened to this school in six years and I am not saying that because I am drunk, I am saying it because I am drunk and it is also true." Her hand was on the frame. "Go home at Easter. That's all. Just go home at Easter and come back in April and do your exams and go to Oxford and be somebody, and do not spend the rest of your life on us."

"Perry."

"Goodnight, my darling," said Perdita, and went, and shut the door with great care, as though it were the door of a room where somebody was sleeping.

In the morning she was at breakfast at half eight with her hair done, arguing with Teddy about a film, and she said, "God, I was appalling last night, was I appalling? I do apologise, I get maudlin, it's my mother's fault," in a voice pitched for the table, and Nell said it was fine, and Perdita said, "I do talk the most colossal rubbish when I've had gin, you must ignore literally everything," and buttered her toast, and looked at Nell exactly once, for about a quarter of a second, over the top of it.

Nell put it in the notebook that afternoon, on the page of things people had said and taken back.

She shouldn't have gone down. We told her not to. I have left it since November.

And under that: November. The Pemberton was advertised in November.

The Scholarship

The Pemberton had a board of its own in the entrance hall, to the left of the fireplace, under the war years with no names on them.

Nell had walked past it perhaps two hundred times. She stood in front of it on the Saturday morning with her hands in her pockets while the hall filled and emptied around her with people going to matches, and read it properly for the first time.

THE PEMBERTON FOUNDATION, 1893. Then a column of names and years, in gold, two or three a decade, all the way down. J. A. HARRIS 1894. T. OKONKWO 1959. There were nineteen names from before the war and thirty after it and the lettering changed style twice.

The last name on the board was S. B. ACHEBE, and the year beside it.

Under that there was an empty space where the painter would put the next one, and the space was the height of one line.

Nell went to the library.

The library at Ravensfell was two rooms, the reading room with the long tables and the annexe with the two printers that jammed, and off the annexe there was a third space that was not really a room, more a corridor with shelves, where the school kept the things that were nobody's subject: the bound volumes of the school magazine going back to 1904, the register of governors, the endowment reports, the leavers' lists in their binder.

She had been in there twice. Nobody else went in there at all.

It took her forty minutes to find it, and when she found it it was not hidden in the least, which was the thing that struck her afterwards. It was in the ordinary annual paperwork of a school that has to publish what it does with its money, in a

stapled document called SCHEDULE OF AWARDS AND BURSARIES, printed for the governors, one copy for the library.

She turned to the P.

PEMBERTON FOUNDATION SCHOLARSHIP. Full fees and boarding, one award. Advertised: November of the preceding year. Examination: February. Interview: March. Award: March, for entry in the following September.

Advertised in November. Awarded in March. For September.

She sat down on the floor between the shelves with the document on her knees, because there was no chair, and read it three times, and then went and got the previous six years of the same document off the shelf and checked every single one, and every single one said November, February, March, September.

Then she found the current year's, which had been printed in October, and it said the same.

So the Pemberton had been advertised in November, as it always was, in October's printed schedule, as it always was, for the September intake, as it always was, and none of that was strange at all.

What was strange was that in December they had given it to a girl in Hull, in nine days, for January.

There was one more thing on the shelf and she nearly did not take it down, because it was the duller object in the room: a lever arch file marked GOVERNORS, MINUTES, with three years in it on thin paper.

She took it down because she had time and because the annexe was warm.

The governors of Ravensfell College met four times a year and their minutes were four pages long and consisted almost entirely of the words noted and approved. Nell read a year of them in twenty minutes and learned that the school had replaced a boiler, lost a case about a right of way, and spent an extraordinary amount of time on the question of parking.

Then she got to the November meeting.

Item 7. Bursary and scholarship provision. The Bursar reported that the Pemberton Foundation was substantially underspent, the accumulated income now standing at a figure that made Nell put the file down on her knees and look at the ceiling for a moment. It was more money than her mother would earn in eleven years.

The Head of Classics addressed the meeting. Dr. Fenn observed that a foundation which awards one scholarship a year out of an income sufficient for four

is not underspent by accident but by policy, and asked that the wording of the trust deed be circulated. The Bursar undertook to circulate it. Noted.

And then, at the end, in the flat language of a woman writing down what was said in a room:

Dr. Fenn stated that she would be bringing a specific case to the March meeting and asked that it be minuted now that she had said so.

Nell read it four times.

November. A specific case. Minuted now that she had said so, which is what a person does when they expect, later, to have to prove that they said it.

She put the file back and it was only on the walk to the window that the second half of it arrived, and it arrived cold.

Dr. Fenn had told a room full of governors in November that she would bring them a case in March.

She had never brought it. In January a girl had died, and by the end of that same month a scholarship had been awarded to a seventeen year old in Hull, in nine days, out of a fund the bursar had spent a decade sitting on, and no case had ever gone to the March meeting at all.

Nell put the documents back in exactly the order she had taken them and went and stood at the window of the annexe and looked out at the frozen pitches with her arms folded.

There were two possible shapes and she made herself lay them both out, in order, fairly, the way you lay out variants.

The first was Sam's shape, which he had given her on the road in her first week, and which she had been carrying around ever since like something she had thought of herself. There was money in the endowment doing nothing. Fenn had been at war with the bursar about it. A place came free in January, and Fenn saw a chance to make her point with a body in the seat, and drove a normal award through in nine days out of sheer force of personality. Fenn wins arguments by making things true.

That shape fitted everything. It fitted the nine days, and the paper Mrs. Aspinall had invigilated in the school library, and the fact that Nell had never had an interview, and Fenn saying I knew it was you in November.

It fitted so well that Nell had never once examined it.

She examined it now, and the whole thing came apart in her hands in about ninety seconds, on one word.

November.

Because Fenn had said November. Nell had a note of it, from her first week, written down that same evening: I knew it was you. In November. As soon as I read it.

Read what?

She had assumed, then, that Fenn meant the application. But there was no application in November. There could not have been. The place did not come free until the fourteenth of January, and the letter had come to Hull on the nineteenth of December, and Nell had done the paper in nine days after that, and the paper was the only thing she had ever submitted to Ravensfell College in her life.

Unless.

She went back to the shelves and got down the bound school magazine for the previous year, and the year before that, and found nothing, and then thought about it properly and went and asked Mrs. Enderby, on Monday, with a reason that was true.

"I want to write to the person who set my scholarship paper," she said. "To say thank you. Is that a thing people do or is it strange?"

"It is a very nice thing to do and nobody has done it since 2011," said Mrs. Enderby, and told her.

The Pemberton paper was set by the head of department. The head of department was Dr. Fenn. And the entries for the Pemberton, in the ordinary course of things, came in from schools in the autumn, on a form, with a reference and a piece of written work.

"But I didn't send anything in the autumn."

"No," Mrs. Enderby said. "You were a late entry. It happens. Your school sent your work in on the general list."

"What general list?"

Mrs. Enderby looked at her with a small and unexpected patience.

"Every year we write to about three hundred state schools in the north and ask them to send us the best written work in their sixth form," she said. "It is a thing the governors like to be able to say we do. Most of them do not reply. The ones that do, we read, and we write back to the child and say well done, and once in a very long while somebody in this building says, that one."

Nell stood very still.

"When does that go out?"

"The letters go out in September and the work comes back through the autumn," said Mrs. Enderby. "We would have had yours in November."

November.

Nell said thank you very much, and went out into the corridor, and stood with her hand flat on the cold plaster of the wall.

Dr. Aurelia Fenn had read four hundred words by a seventeen year old in Hull in November, and had said, that one.

And in November nobody at Ravensfell College had any reason on earth to want a spare girl.

In November, Cassia Brandt was alive, and in her room at the top of the West Tower, and had been leaving something since November, and had another eight weeks to live.

Margot

March came in with three days of rain that took the last of the snow off the north walls, and on the second of them Margot knocked on the door of room fourteen at four in the afternoon, which was not a time anybody ever knocked, and said:

"Come out. I am going to show you something and then I am going to talk, and you are going to let me finish, which you find difficult."

They walked. Not up the track, which was running with water, but down the drive and out and along the road under the beeches with the rain coming sideways off the moor, and Margot did not talk for the first mile, and Nell had learned by then to let her not.

Where the wall turned there was a gate, and past the gate a field, and in the corner of the field an ash tree with a bench under it, put there by somebody's family in 1987 according to the plate, and Margot sat down on the wet bench in the rain and Nell sat down next to her.

"She used to come here," Margot said. "Every Sunday. Not for the view. There is no view, it is a field. She came because it is the first place on that road where you cannot see the college."

Nell turned round. It was true. The wall and the rise took the building out completely. There was nothing behind them but hedge and hill.

"Right," Margot said. "Now I will tell you about her, and you will not write it down, because I have seen your notebook."

"Margot."

"I am not angry about the notebook. I would keep a notebook." She wiped the rain off her face with the flat of her hand. "You have been here nine weeks and you

have collected everybody's version of her and I want to give you the one nobody will give you, which is what she was like on a Tuesday."

And she did.

She talked for forty minutes in the rain, in her second language, and it was the best thing anybody said in that whole term.

She said that Cassia Brandt had been a hypocrite about tea, and would tell people that she did not care about it, and then be silently furious for an hour if it was made in a mug rather than a pot. She said that she read in the bath until the water was cold, and that she had once got out of a bath at two in the morning with the ends of her hair frozen to her neck because the window had blown open. She said that she was frightened of dogs and pretended it was an ethical position. That she could do the whole of the opening of the Iliad from memory and could not remember the birthday of a single member of her own family. That she was the only person Margot had ever known who did not perform anything, at all, ever, and that this was not a virtue, it was a disability, because a person who cannot perform cannot be kind at the cost of the truth, and there are days when the only kind thing available is a small lie.

"She told me my English was getting worse," Margot said. "In front of Teddy. Because it was true, I was tired, I was speaking badly that week. Anyone else in the world would have waited." She looked at her hands. "And that night she came and sat on my bed and did the verbs with me for two hours, and did not mention it, and would not have understood why I might want her to."

"That sounds unbearable."

"It was often unbearable." Margot's mouth moved. "It was also the only friendship I have had where I never once wondered what the other person actually thought of me. Do you know how rare that is? I have known Perdita for six years and I have no idea. None. With Cassia you knew every day, because if she thought it she said it, and if she had not said it she did not think it."

The rain got heavier and neither of them moved.

"She was not a saint," Margot said. "I want to be accurate. She was arrogant, and she was hard on people who were slower, and she thought that being right was the same as being good, which is the mistake of clever children who have never been badly wrong about anything." A pause. "And she was wrong about that. Being right is not the same as being good. It is not even close."

"What was she right about?"

Margot did not answer.

"On the stairs," Nell said, "in my first week, you told me not to compare. I've thought about it every day since and I still don't know what you meant."

"I know you have."

"So tell me."

Margot sat forward with her elbows on her knees and the rain running off her hood, and she was quiet for so long that Nell thought she was not going to.

"I meant two things," she said, "and I only knew about one of them when I said it, and the other one has taken me a year, so you will have to be patient with me."

"All right."

"The first thing. You sleep in her room and you sit in her chair in that seminar and Fenn looks at you the way she used to look at her, and every single person in this school is doing the arithmetic. And if you start doing it too, you will spend two years being a second edition of a girl you never met, and you will never once be a first edition of yourself." Margot turned her head. "That is what I meant. That is the thing an ordinary friend says. Do not compare yourself to her."

"And the second?"

"The second," said Margot, "I did not know I was saying."

She stood up. She walked four paces out into the wet grass with her back to Nell and stood there in the field in the rain.

"You put things side by side," she said. "It is what you do. It is what Fenn taught you to do in the first week, with the variants, this manuscript says this and that manuscript says that, and the truth is in the gap. And I watched you do it to us, one at a time, in January, with your little questions." Her voice did not rise at all. "Do not compare. It was the most stupid thing I have ever said out loud, because it was a warning, and I gave it to the one person clever enough to hear it as a clue."

Nell's ears were roaring.

"Margot."

"Do not ask me. I am asking you not to ask me."

"That's the second person this week who's asked me that."

"Then two of us are cowards." Margot turned round. Her face was wet and it was rain, or it was not, and there was no way to tell in a field in March. "I will tell you one thing and it is the last thing I will say about her, and then we are going to walk back and have supper and talk about the Latin, because I cannot do this every day."

"Say it."

"She was not going to leave." Margot said it steadily and it cost her enormously. "Whatever anyone has told you about that night. Wherever they have told you she went. She had eighteen months of work in that room and a place at Cambridge to sit for in the autumn and she was the least sentimental person I have ever met about her own future. There was nothing on this earth that would have made Cassia Brandt walk out of Ravensfell College in the middle of the winter term and not come back."

"Her father was ill."

"Her father," said Margot, "died in 1919."

The rain came across the field in a curtain. Somewhere down the road a car went past without slowing.

"I sat in a room in January," Margot said, "and I heard Teddy say the words her father is ill, and I did not open my mouth, and I have not opened it since, and that is who I am now. That is the whole of it. You wanted to know what she was like on a Tuesday. That is what I am like on a Tuesday."

She walked back up the field to the gate and held it open, and waited, and Nell went through it, and they walked the mile and a half back to the college in the rain without saying anything at all, and at the boot room door Margot stopped and took her by the wrist, hard, the scarred hand, and said:

"Ask Ivo. He said a week and it is Wednesday. Ask Ivo, and do not, whatever else you do, tell Teddy that you are going to."

The Rota

The chapel bell at Ravensfell was rung at eleven o'clock every night of term except Sundays, and had been since 1847, and nobody could tell Nell why.

She asked four people. The chaplain said it was a curfew bell originally and had simply never been stopped. Teddy said it was to do with the mines. Perdita said it was to annoy the village. Ivo said it was because a boy had drowned in the beck in 1846 walking back in the dark and the bell was so that anybody out on the moor would know which way the college was, and that this was in the governors' minutes and everybody else was guessing.

The rota was kept in the vestry, on a clipboard, on a nail.

It was a single sheet per term, printed, with the dates down the left and the names beside them, and the chaplain filled it in at the start of term from a list of volunteers and never thought about it again. Boys and girls from the fourth year up. Two week rotation, so each person did four or five nights a term.

The current one was on the nail. Under it, on the same nail, were the ones from the two terms before, and under those, going back on the same nail because nobody had ever taken them off, were about fifteen sheets, curled and dusty, held by the same drawing pin, in reverse order like the leaves of a very badly made book.

Nell counted back and found the winter term of the year before on the ninth sheet down.

She had to lift the eight in front of it and hold them, and she did that, standing in the cold vestry at twenty past four in the afternoon on the Wednesday, with the rain on the window, and she read down the left hand column to 14 JAN and put her finger on the line.

14 JAN. BRANDT.

Nell stood in the vestry holding eight sheets of paper.

The rota said that on the night of the fourteenth of January, the person rostered to ring the eleven o'clock bell at Ravensfell College was Cassia Brandt.

She made herself do it properly. She read the whole sheet, top to bottom, both columns, and checked the dates either side, and the names, and then she got out her notebook and copied the entire fortnight of it, every date and every name, because she had learned that you take the whole thing and not the bit you want.

11	JAN.	OLLERENSHAW.
12	JAN.	LINDQVIST.
13	JAN.	ASHWORTH-KANE.
14	JAN.	BRANDT.
15	JAN.	LINDQVIST.
16	JAN. RENARD.	

Ivo had been down for the twelfth, and again for the fifteenth. Not the fourteenth.

She put the sheets back on the nail exactly as she had found them and went out through the chapel, past the coiled rope with its worn leather grip, and stood in the porch and looked at the rain coming down on the gravel, and did the arithmetic on her fingers like a child.

Three people had told her, without being asked twice, that Ivo Lindqvist had rung the eleven o'clock bell on the night of the fourteenth of January.

Ivo had told her the same, and had given her a duration, and an exact finishing time, and had said I am sure, and Ivo did not say I am sure about things.

The rota said Cassia.

Sam had said that whoever rang the bell that night had rung it badly.

Nell went and sat on the wall by the porch in the rain because her legs had gone peculiar, and made herself construct it, slowly, the way you construct a translation.

The bell rang that night. Sam heard it. That was not in dispute, because if the bell had not rung at all somebody would have noticed, in a building of a hundred and forty people who had heard it every night of their lives, and the chaplain would have written to somebody's parents about it.

The bell was Cassia's job that night.

If Cassia had rung it, she was alive and in the chapel at eleven o'clock, and the bell would have been rung by a girl who had done it a dozen times, and it would have sounded ordinary.

The bell was rung badly.

Therefore Cassia did not ring it.

Therefore somebody else went into the chapel that night and pulled that rope for eighteen minutes, badly, in the dark, at eleven o'clock, on the night that Cassia Brandt disappeared.

And whoever it was had known she would not be coming to do it.

That was the sentence that arrived whole, sitting on a wet wall in the rain, and Nell said it out loud to the gravel, twice, to hear whether it survived being said.

You do not cover somebody's bell unless you know they are not coming.

There was one more thing and she made herself have it, although by then she wanted very much to stop.

The bell was rung so that the school would hear a bell at eleven o'clock. Not so that nothing would seem wrong to somebody out on the moor. So that nothing would seem wrong inside the building. A hundred and forty people had gone to sleep that night in a school where the eleven o'clock bell had rung exactly as it rang every night, and not one of them had lain awake and thought, that is odd, nobody rang.

Somebody had thought of that. On the night itself. Within the hour.

Nell sat on the wall in the rain and understood, for the first time, that she was not investigating an accident, or a disappearance, or a girl who had walked into the cold.

She was reading a thing that had been composed.

She went to find the chaplain, because there was one thing she could still get wrong and she was not going to get it wrong.

He was in the vestry at five, doing something with candle stubs, and he was a mild man of about sixty who had taught her nothing and had said good morning to her every single day since January, which was more than several people who had taught her a great deal.

"Can I ask about the bell rota?"

"You can have a go on it if you like. We are always short in the summer."

"No, I mean, if someone can't do their night. What happens?"

"They swap," said the chaplain. "They find somebody and they swap and they tell me, or more often they do not tell me, and I find out because I hear the wrong person's rhythm. You can tell, you know. After thirty years you can tell who is on it from the pattern of the strokes." He wiped his hands on a cloth. "Lindqvist is the

best ringer this school has had since a boy called Mackenzie in the nineties. Absolutely metronomic. It is quite eerie."

"And if nobody rings it at all?"

"Then I would hear that even more clearly," the chaplain said, "since I live forty feet from it and I have not slept through eleven o'clock since 1994."

"Has that ever happened? A night with no bell?"

He thought about it, and Nell watched a mild man take an ordinary question seriously.

"Twice," he said. "Once when the frame cracked, and we had it off for a fortnight in 2011. And once in a snow, when a boy could not get across the Quad, and one of the staff did it instead, badly, and everybody complained at breakfast." He smiled. "That is the thing about a bell. It is the loudest thing in the valley and nobody hears it, and then one night it is wrong and a hundred and forty people mention it before nine in the morning."

Nell thanked him and went out.

A hundred and forty people would mention it before nine in the morning.

Which meant that on the fifteenth of January, the morning after, in a school where a bell rung badly gets complained about over the toast, nobody had complained. Because it had rung. On time. For eighteen minutes.

At five to eleven that night she was in the chapel porch with the rain still going and her hood up, and at eleven exactly Ivo Lindqvist came round the corner of the cloister with his coat collar turned up, and stopped when he saw her, and did not seem surprised.

"You are early," he said.

"So are you."

"I am always early. It takes eighteen minutes and it must finish at eleven twenty." He unlocked the chapel door with a key from a ring of about nine. "Come in out of it."

Inside it was black and cold and smelled of paraffin. He did not put the light on. He took the rope off its hook and stood there with the leather grip in both hands, and Nell stood four feet away, and neither of them could see the other properly.

"You said a week," she said.

"I said a week."

"It's been a week."

"Yes."

He pulled. The bell went, enormously, straight above their heads, the whole tower taking it, and the sound came down the stone and into the floor and up through Nell's boots, and Ivo let the rope run back up through his hands and caught it again on the fall, and pulled, and the bell went again, evenly, exactly as it had gone every night since 1847.

He rang it for eighteen minutes and did not miss once.

At eleven twenty he stopped, and stood holding the rope until it went still, and coiled it in even loops and hung it on the hook.

Then he said, in the dark, in a voice that had nothing left in it at all:

"Ask me."

Teddy

"Ask me," Ivo said.

Nell had had a week to build the question and in the end she used four words.

"Where did she go?"

"She did not go," said Ivo. "She never left the grounds."

The chapel door opened.

It opened on a wedge of torchlight and rain noise, and a voice said, pleasantly, from the porch:

"Ivo. Go to bed."

Nobody moved for a second. Then Ivo put his hand flat on the back of the nearest pew, the way a man does when he has been standing a long time, and went past Teddy Ashworth-Kane and out into the rain without a word, and his footsteps went away across the gravel, and Teddy came in and let the door swing shut behind him and put the torch down on the pew end so that it lit the ceiling.

"Right," he said. "This is not a conversation for a church. Come to the library, it has chairs and a radiator and there is nobody in it after eleven."

"Are you going to tell me to go to bed as well?"

"I am going to tell you," Teddy said, "that you are standing in a freezing building in wet clothes at twenty past eleven at night and that if you get ill in March in your first year you will lose a fortnight you cannot afford. And then, yes, I am going to have the conversation, because we are past the point where not having it is doing anybody any good."

They went to the library. He was right about the radiator. He put two chairs at right angles under the reading lamp at the far end, in the corridor of shelves where nobody went, and he sat down and put his head back and shut his eyes for a

moment, and Nell saw that he was exhausted, in the deep way, the way of somebody who has been tired since a specific date.

"How long have you known?" she said.

"That you were going to find out? Since about the third week of January. Since you asked five people the same question in the same words in five days and thought nobody would compare notes." He opened his eyes. "We are not very clever, Nell. That is what everybody gets wrong about this place. We are extremely well taught. It is not the same thing. You are cleverer than all five of us and you were cleverer than us in your first fortnight, and that has been, honestly, the most frightening development of my life."

"Ivo said she never left the grounds."

"Yes."

"Is she dead?"

"Yes," said Teddy.

The radiator ticked. Somewhere at the other end of the library a window was loose in its frame and moving very slightly in the wind, over and over, a small knocking.

Nell found that she had known for some time and that knowing had been nothing at all like being told.

"Say it properly," she said.

"Cassia Brandt died on the night of the fourteenth of January last year, on this estate, and she has been here ever since, and I know where, and I have known since about twenty to twelve that night." Teddy's voice did not shake. He said it the way you say a thing you have said to yourself several thousand times in the dark. "Nobody meant it. That is not an excuse and I am not offering it as one, I am telling you the fact because you will need it to understand everything else. There was no plan. There was an argument in the clock loft and a girl went down the hill and another girl went after her, and eleven minutes later everything that has happened since had already happened."

"Who?"

"No."

"Teddy."

"No," he said. "Not because I am protecting anyone from you. Because you have worked out about eleven twelfths of this on your own with a notebook from a village shop, and if I hand you the last twelfth then you did not find it, you were

given it, and there is a difference in law and there is a bigger difference in what it will do to you." He leaned forward. "Ask Ivo. He will tell you now, he has been trying to tell you for a month, and I have been standing in doorways stopping him because I am a coward. But it will be Ivo who tells you, and not me."

"That is a very convenient principle."

"It is completely convenient," Teddy agreed. "Most principles are. It happens also to be right."

Nell sat with her wet coat steaming faintly on the arm of the chair.

"Her father died in 2019," she said.

Teddy went still. It was the first time all term she had seen him arrive at a thing without having got there first.

"Margot told you that."

"Margot told me that. So who told the school he was ill?"

"Nobody told the school anything," Teddy said.

"Somebody must have. There is a letter in the office. I have read it. It is dated the fourteenth of January, it says family reasons, it is signed by her, and Mrs. Enderby had her off eleven lists by the seventeenth."

"Yes."

"Then who wrote it?"

Teddy looked at her for a long moment, and then he laughed, once, without any humour in it at all, a short unhappy sound in a dark library.

"You still think we did all this," he said. "You have sat there for two months thinking that five teenagers moved a body and forged a letter and squared a school and dealt with the police on the road, and it has not once occurred to you to ask the obvious question, which is how five teenagers would have the faintest idea how to do any of that."

The knocking window. The radiator.

"The school wrote it," Nell said.

"The school wrote it," said Teddy. "Of course the school wrote it. We were nineteen years old and we were sitting on the floor of a cellar at midnight being sick, and by four in the morning there were adults in the room, and by the seventeenth there was a letter and a leavers' entry and a girl who had gone home to a family emergency, and not one of us wrote a single word of any of it." He rubbed his face with both hands. "We did the worst thing. I want to be clear, because I have thought about this for fourteen months and I am not going to sit here and be got

off. We did the worst thing, which was that we let them. Every one of us. Including me, and I am the one who went and woke them up, so I am the one who chose which adults."

"Which adults?"

"That," Teddy said, "you already know."

Nell thought of a woman in a dark green jumper turning a sheet of paper round with one finger and reading a letter of withdrawal typed on her own machine, and saying: a document is an object and not a sentiment.

She thought she might be sick.

"Nell," Teddy said.

"Don't."

"I am going to say one thing and then I will take you back to the tower and you can hate me at your leisure." He sat forward with his elbows on his knees, and in the lamplight he was not the boy who had stood on a wall at Lantern Night and made a speech. "You have four weeks of term left. On the twenty-first of March everybody goes home, and in April you come back and you sit the papers that decide the whole of the rest of your life, and there is a woman in this building who will put you into Oxford in eighteen months, and she will do it, because she has done it eleven times and because she thinks you are the best thing she has read in twenty years."

"Is that the offer."

"That is not the offer, that is the situation. This is the offer." He said it very simply. "Stay. Be one of us. Not as a favour, and not on probation, and not as the sixth. We do not want a sixth. We want you, and we have wanted you since about the second week, and Perry cried in the loft in February because she said we had done a monstrous thing bringing you in and now we all loved you. Stay. Take the place. Do the work. Go to Oxford. In nine years none of us will be able to remember what the winter term of that year was actually like, and there is nothing you can do here in four weeks that will bring that girl back up that hill."

"And in exchange I say nothing."

"In exchange," Teddy said, "you say nothing."

He stood up and took his torch off the shelf.

"I want to be honest with you about one part of it, because you will find it out anyway and it is better from me." He clicked the torch on and off, once, looking at it rather than at her. "The offer is real. Every word of it is real, and if you take it we will keep it for the rest of our lives, and you will never once find us cold to you in a

corridor." He looked up. "And I would still be standing here making it if I liked you a great deal less. Both of those are true. I have found that most things are."

Dunleavy

Nell did not go to Ivo for four days.

She told herself it was because Teddy had said it should be Ivo who told her and she would not be handed anything, and that was true, and it was not the reason. The reason was that she was nineteen days from the end of term and she had understood, in a library at midnight, that once she knew the last twelfth of it she would have to do something, and that every hour she did not know was an hour she still had all five of them.

So she went sideways, and she went to the one person in the building nobody had thought about at all.

Mr. Dunleavy had a workshop behind the kitchens with a stove in it and a radio always on and a kettle, and he had been at Ravensfell for thirty-one years, and in nine weeks Nell had never once seen a student speak to him except to complain that a radiator was cold.

She went in on the Saturday afternoon with two mugs of tea she had made in the kitchens and no reason at all.

"I'm not supposed to be in here," she said.

"You're not," Dunleavy agreed, and took the tea.

She sat on an upturned crate. The workshop smelled of paraffin and sawdust and the particular sweetness of two stroke oil. There was a wall of keys behind him on a board, hundreds of them, on brass hooks, each with a paper tag gone brown.

They talked about nothing for twenty minutes. The radio. The football, about which Nell knew enough from her father to be useful. The state of the beeches along the drive, which he said would have to come down within ten years and which nobody would pay for. He was not lonely, exactly, and he was not garrulous. He was

a man who had a lot of information and had been in a place for thirty-one years where nobody had ever asked him for any of it.

"Can I ask you something about the locks?"

"Aye."

"Someone told me they were all changed last summer. The whole estate."

Dunleavy drank his tea. He had a very slow way of not answering that was not evasion, and Nell made herself wait through it, which she had by now had a great deal of practice at.

"No," he said.

"No?"

"Locks get changed when they break." He nodded at the board. "Every one of them keys is a lock on this estate and I've cut a new one four times since Christmas because a lad's lost his. There's no changing them all at once. Where'd you get that from?"

"Somebody said there was a man here in the summer doing the pavilion and the boiler house."

"There was a man here in the summer doing the guttering," said Dunleavy, "and he was here three weeks and he did nothing else, and I know because I put the ladders up for him."

Nell held her mug in both hands.

"The ice house," she said. "Behind the chapel."

The radio played. Dunleavy set his tea down on the bench and did not pick it up again.

"What about it."

"It's got a new padlock on it."

"It has."

"Do you remember when it went on?"

She had thought he might have to think, and had prepared for that, and had a plan for how to help him narrow it down without leading him, which she had worked out lying awake and had been rather proud of.

He did not have to think.

"Fifteenth of January, last year," Dunleavy said.

The stove ticked.

"You're sure."

"I've the docket," he said. "Everything I buy, I get a docket, and the docket goes in the book, because the bursar's office queries anything over a tanner and has done since before you were born." He got up and took a hardbacked ledger off the shelf, the same kind of ledger Mrs. Enderby had, and turned it round on the bench and went back through it with a thick finger. "There. Padlock, brass, long shackle. Chain, no. Chain was already there. Fifteenth of January."

Nell looked at the line. It was written in ballpoint in a careful hand, with the price, and next to it, in the column headed AUTH, three letters.

"What's that?"

"Authority. Who told me to."

"Who is HRA?"

"Head's office," Dunleavy said. "That's Mrs. Enderby writing on behalf. She does the requisitions." He turned the page back, and forward again, and shrugged. "It'd have come down on a slip. I'll not have kept the slip, that goes back up."

"Do you remember being asked?"

"I remember the job," he said, "because it were a queer job, and I said so at the time to Bill Rutherford who's since retired." He tapped the bench. "That building's been shut since the sixties. There's nowt in it. It's not on the insurance schedule because it's not a building, it's a hole with a door. And they had me down there on a Tuesday morning in January with the ground like iron, and they wanted it locked, and they wanted it wedged."

"Wedged?"

"Timber at the foot, packed at the head, so it'd not move in a wind." He looked at her. "You'll have seen it, since you're asking."

"I've seen it."

"Aye. Well." Dunleavy picked his tea back up. "I said to Bill, if you want a thing that badly shut you've either got summat in it or you're keeping summat out, and there's nowt on this estate wants keeping out but rabbits."

Nell heard her own voice from a long way off.

"Did anybody ever tell you why?"

"I'm not told why, pet. I'm told what."

"And the key?"

"Two keys with a padlock. One went up to the office with the docket." He drank. "T'other's on that board."

Nell turned round on the crate and looked at the wall of brass hooks and brown paper tags, and her whole body went cold and light at once, the way it does at the top of a stair in the dark.

"Which one?"

Dunleavy did not get up. He had been perfectly easy for half an hour and he was not easy now, and he looked at her over the mug for what felt like a long time, an old man in a workshop with a girl of eighteen sitting on his crate.

"You want to think on," he said.

"I know."

"Do you." He set the mug down. "I'll say this to you once, and then I'll say nowt else and you'll not come back and ask me. I've been here thirty-one year. I've seen bairns come in at thirteen and go out at eighteen and I've unblocked their drains and put their bikes back together and I've never once been in a room where a decision were made. Not once." His face did not change. "That's how it works. Them that decide are up there, and them that hold the keys are down here, and the whole trick of the place is that we're not the same people."

"Mr. Dunleavy."

"So I'll tell you what I know, because you asked me straight and nobody's asked me straight in thirty-one year," he said. "And then it's yours. Because I'm sixty-two and I've a pension due in three, and I'll not carry it, and I'll not pretend I don't know I'm handing it to a lass of eighteen instead."

He got up and went to the board and took a key off a hook near the bottom, on the left, where the tags were oldest, and put it on the bench between them.

The tag said ICE HO. in brown ink, in a hand that had died before either of them was born.

The key was new.

"There it is," said Dunleavy. "It's been on that wall since the fifteenth of January last year and not one soul has asked me for it. Not one." He sat down heavily. "And I'll tell you the thing that's kept me awake, and then we're done. When a building's locked and there's a key on my board, the groundsmen go in it. For the strimmers, the netting, the marker paint, whatever. It's storage. That's what a locked building is on an estate, it's storage."

"And?"

"And in fourteen month," Dunleavy said, "nobody's asked to store owt in it."

He put the key back on its hook, which Nell had not expected, and sat down again.

"I'll not carry it and I'll not hand it over neither," he said, seeing her face. "It stops where it's stopped for fourteen month, on that board, in my workshop, where anybody with a right to it can come and ask me. That's what I'm for. If you want that door open you'll not do it with me handing you a key in the dark like a pair of thieves."

"I wasn't going to ask you for it."

"You were three minutes off it," said Dunleavy, "and you'd have been right to, and I'd have said no, and you'd not have come back, and I'd have thought about that in three years' time on a Tuesday." He wrapped both hands round his mug. "So here's what I'll do instead, and then I'm done. You bring somebody with a warrant card down that hill, and I'll walk down with you and I'll put that key in the lock myself in front of them and I'll say the date out of that ledger, out loud, so it's not a lass of eighteen saying it."

Nell looked at the stove.

"Why would you do that?"

"Because I've a granddaughter of sixteen at the comprehensive in Hexham," Dunleavy said, "and if she'd gone missing from a place and them that ran it had written a letter about it, I'd want a lad like me to have opened his mouth."

He drained the tea and set the mug in the sink and turned the radio back up, which was how she knew it was over.

The File

Dunleavy had been right, and she knew he was right before she was out of the workshop, and it took her two days to admit that she had been three minutes from asking him for the key.

If she had opened that door alone, then whatever was inside it would have belonged, from that moment, to a story about a scholarship girl who had gone poking about on an estate where she did not belong. She had watched this school take a dead girl and turn her into a letter in a fortnight. She had no illusions whatever about what the same building would do with a live one from Hull.

What she had instead was better and she had not earned it: a man with thirty-one years and a ledger, who would walk down that hill in daylight and say a date out loud in front of somebody with a warrant card.

Which meant she needed the somebody, and the warrant card, and before either of those she needed the thing she did not yet have.

What she needed first was paper, because paper was the only thing that had told her the truth all term. People had given her versions. The laundry docket, the rota, the leavers' list, the schedule of awards, the governors' minutes and a ledger in a workshop had given her facts, and every single one of them had been sitting in the open where anybody could have looked, for fourteen months, and nobody had.

The office was locked at night. But the office had a hatch to the corridor, and the hatch had a bolt on the inside, and on the Monday afternoon Nell went in to change her address on the chapel rota, as Mrs. Enderby had told her to do three weeks before, and while Mrs. Enderby was at the far end of the room with the box files she leaned on the counter and slid the bolt back with one finger.

She was sick with herself for four hours afterwards. She did it anyway.

At half past ten that night she came back down the dark corridor in her socks, with a torch, and put both hands flat on the hatch and pushed, and it swung inward, and she climbed through onto the counter and down.

The room smelled of toner and old paper. She did not put the light on. She had eleven minutes, she had decided, and she had written down in advance exactly what she was looking for, because she had learned that you do not go into an archive and browse.

She found the first thing in four minutes: the requisition slips, on a spike, by year, because Ravensfell College had been putting slips on a spike since 1954 and nobody had ever stopped.

15 JANUARY. Padlock and fixings, ice house, to be secured and wedged, urgent, obtain today. Chg. to estates.

At the bottom, in the box marked AUTHORISED, there was a signature.

It was not Mrs. Enderby's. Mrs. Enderby wrote on behalf, in her round capitals, and there were forty slips on that spike in her round capitals.

This one was signed in a small, fast, extremely legible hand, in black ink, with a fountain pen.

A. Fenn.

Nell stood in the dark office and looked at it for longer than she could afford.

The second thing took her another five minutes and she nearly missed it, because she was looking in the wrong drawer, and it was not in a drawer at all but in a wire tray on top of the cabinet marked TO BE FILED, which had clearly been marked TO BE FILED for some years.

It was a photocopy of a letter to the bursar, dated the sixteenth of January.

Dear Michael,

Further to my remarks to the governors in November, I am bringing the Pemberton case forward and I intend to act on it before the end of this month rather than in March. The candidate is Eleanor Kavanagh of Kingsley Academy, whose work I circulated to you in November and about whom you were kind enough to say that she was exactly the sort of case the Foundation exists for.

You will say that the timing is unfortunate. I would put it differently. We have a place, we have an income the Foundation has failed to spend for eleven years, and we have a girl who will not get another chance at this. I would rather do one good thing quickly than three good things in committee.

I should be grateful if you would treat this as urgent and not raise it at a meeting.

Yours,

Aurelia

Nell sat down on the floor of the office in the dark with the photocopy in her hand and the torch off, and she was crying, and she could not have said, then or ever, precisely what for.

The sixteenth of January. Two days after.

Every word of it was true. That was the thing. Every single word of that letter was true and she could have checked all of it: the November minutes were on the shelf in the library, the work had been circulated, the Foundation had been underspent for eleven years, and Nell Kavanagh of Kingsley Academy would not have got another chance at this, and had not, and knew it.

It was also, read from two days after the fourteenth of January, the coldest document she had ever held.

We have a place.

Nell put the photocopy back in the wire tray exactly where it had been, under the two things that had been on top of it. She put the slip back on the spike in the right order. She climbed back out through the hatch and pushed it shut and did not, because she could not reach it, slide the bolt back across, which she thought about all night and which nobody ever mentioned.

She went up the sixty-one stairs and sat on the bed in room fourteen in her coat.

And she made herself do the thing she had been trained to do, which was to lay the variants side by side without deciding in advance what she wanted them to say.

Version one. A teacher had read a piece of work by a poor clever girl in November and had gone to war for her with a bursar, and in January a place had come free in the worst possible way, and she had used it, because a woman who has spent eleven years watching a fund sit idle does not let a place go past. On this version Fenn had done a good thing out of a bad one, and had signed a requisition for a padlock because somebody had to, and Nell owed her everything.

Version two. Exactly the same facts, in the same order, with one difference: that on the fifteenth of January Aurelia Fenn had locked and wedged a door, and on the sixteenth she had written a letter to fill the empty seat, and that she had done the second thing because she had done the first.

Nell sat with the two of them for a long time.

They were not distinguishable by any evidence she had. They would not be distinguishable by any evidence she could get. Both were consistent with every

document in that building, and would be until the end of time, and she understood that this was not an accident either: that a certain kind of mind does not falsify a record, it simply arranges to be innocent on paper, and that the arrangement is the crime and cannot be photographed.

There was one more thing she made herself look at before she put the torch out, and it was not a document.

She had been in this school for ten weeks and in that time she had been given, free and unasked, more kindness than she had received in the previous three years: a warm room at the top of a tower, a good blanket, a walk to a village shop, a toast at a bonfire, two hours a day of the best teaching in England, and a woman with a pencil who had told her that she must not learn to sound like an answer.

Every single one of those things was real.

Every single one of them had also been useful to somebody.

That was the discovery, and it had taken her until three in the morning on the tenth of March to make it, and it was worth more than any of the paper. Nobody in this building had faked anything. That was what she had got wrong in January, when she had been looking for a lie. There was no lie. There was a school in which every good impulse anybody had was quietly harvested, the way a mill takes a stream that would have run downhill anyway, and the water does not know, and the water is not diminished, and at the bottom there is a wheel turning that nobody chose to build.

She wrote that down badly, in about forty words, and read it back, and struck out half of it because it sounded like something a girl says to make a bad thing bearable.

What was left was five words, and she looked at them for a long time.

They will not have lied.

It was the most useful sentence she wrote that term. It told her exactly what she would find when she asked the last two people, and it was why, on the Thursday, she did not go to Fenn expecting a denial, and why, when the denial did not come, she was the only person in the room who was not surprised.

At two in the morning she wrote one line under it and put the notebook away.

Ask her. She is the only one who will not lie, because she does not think she has done anything.

What Ivo Saw

Ivo took her to the clock loft, which she had not expected, and which she understood when they got there: it was the warmest room in the building, and it was where it had started, and he had been climbing those stairs for fourteen months.

He sat on the floor with his back against the housing of the clock mechanism and put the older notebook on the boards between them, with the rubber band still round it.

"I will tell it in order," he said, "because if I do not I will tell it badly. Do not ask me questions in the middle. You may ask everything at the end."

"All right."

"It begins in November," Ivo said, "and it begins with something so small that you will not believe it, and everybody who is ever told about this will not believe it, and that is the part I have thought about most."

In November there had been a paper.

Not an examination. A mock, an internal one, set by the Classics department in the second week of term, for the six of them in the seminar, because Fenn liked to know where people were before the Cambridge entries went in. It did not count for anything. It was not sealed, or invigilated, or kept anywhere in particular. It was four sides of A4 in a folder on a desk.

Teddy Ashworth-Kane had read it, three days before, in the Fenn Room, on his own, because it was there.

"He did not take it," Ivo said. "He did not photograph it. He read it, and then he told Perry, because he tells Perry everything, and Perry told me because she was frightened, and I told nobody, and Margot found out from Teddy himself because he thought it was funny."

Four of them had known the questions.

"Did you do anything with it?"

"You are asking a question in the middle."

"Sorry."

"Yes," said Ivo. "That is the answer. I did well in that paper and I had not done well in the one before, and Fenn said so, in the room, in front of everybody, that I had improved. I said thank you." He was looking at the floor. "Perry did nothing with it. She wrote what she would have written anyway, she is not academic, it made no difference. Teddy did what Teddy does. Margot was the only one of us who told him he was an idiot and then used it anyway."

"And Cassia?"

"Cassia did not know."

He said it very simply and it took Nell a second to feel the shape of it.

"She came top," Ivo said. "She always came top. She came top in a paper where four of the other five had seen the questions, and she did not know, and she came top by a very long way, and Fenn read her paper out loud."

"Oh," Nell said.

"Yes. Oh." Ivo turned the notebook over on the boards. "She found out at the end of November. Perry told her, drunk, in this room, because Perry cannot hold anything, and then said she had been joking, and Cassia went away and did not say a word about it for six weeks."

I have left it since November.

"Why did she wait?"

"You are asking questions in the middle again."

"I know. Answer it anyway."

"Because she was thinking about what it was," said Ivo. "That is what nobody who did not know her will ever understand. She was not building up her courage. She did not need courage, she never needed courage, it was not one of her difficulties. She spent six weeks working out whether reporting a mock paper that counted for nothing was a proportionate thing to do to four people she had known since she was thirteen." He looked up for the first time. "She decided that it was. On the fourteenth of January she told us at supper that she was going to the head in the morning, and that she was telling us first because it would have been contemptible not to."

"And you argued."

"We argued for four hours," Ivo said. "Here. In this room."

He told it flatly and in order, as he had said he would.

Teddy had argued. Teddy had argued brilliantly, for two hours, and had used every register he had: that it was nothing, that it would not be treated as nothing, that Perry would be thrown out and Perry had a mother who would not survive it in public, that Sam had a reference in the balance, that Ivo's father would take him out of the school in a fortnight, that Cassia was proposing to blow up five lives over four sides of A4 that had gone in the bin in November.

And Cassia had said, over and over, in the same words, that she was not proposing to do anything to anybody, that she was proposing to tell the truth about a thing that had happened, and that what happened after that was not her department.

"She was right," Ivo said. "She was right and she was unbearable and both of those were true at the same time, and I have had fourteen months to find a way in which she was wrong and I have not found one."

At about eleven o'clock she had got up and said she was going down to get the folder.

"The folder?"

"The paper. The actual paper. Teddy's copy, the one he had read, was in the ice house with the rest of our things." Ivo's mouth moved. "We kept things there. Drink, mostly. Cigarettes. A camping stove, at one point, which was insane. Six years of that. It is the only place on the estate nobody goes, and it has a door, and every one of us had been down there a hundred times."

"In the dark."

"There is a torch on a nail inside the door," said Ivo. "There has been a torch on that nail since we were fourteen."

Cassia had gone down the hill on her own, at about eleven, in the padded coat, in minus four.

Margot had gone after her about a minute later.

"Why?"

"To talk to her." Ivo's voice did not change. "I want to be exact, because everything about this depends on being exact and I have been the only person keeping the account. Margot went down to talk to her. She did not go down to stop her, she went down to talk to her, and I know that because I heard what she said as she went out of that door, and she said, I will go, she will listen to me."

"And Teddy?"

"Teddy stayed here and Perry stayed here and I stayed here," Ivo said, "and that is the thing I will be answering for when I am sixty."

They had been eleven minutes.

At eleven, or a little after, the bell began.

"That is where you are wrong," Ivo said, "and I have wanted to correct you for a month and I could not. You have worked out that somebody rang that bell knowing she would not come. That is not what happened. Nobody knew anything at eleven o'clock. She was alive at eleven o'clock." He put both hands flat on the notebook. "The bell rang because it was her turn, and because somebody in this school realised at five to eleven that the person on the rota was not in the building, and went and did it so that she would not get a black mark."

Nell felt the whole shape of it turn over.

"Somebody covered for her."

"Somebody covered for her," said Ivo. "Out of kindness. At five to eleven, when nothing had happened yet. And then at twenty past eleven, when Margot came back up that hill, that same act of kindness had become the reason that a hundred and forty people went to bed hearing an ordinary night."

He was quiet for a moment.

"I have thought about that more than about anything else," he said. "More than the argument, more than the steps, more than what we did afterwards, which was worse. Because everything we did after midnight, we chose. Every part of it. But that bell was rung by somebody who was doing a small favour for a friend at five to eleven at night, and it did more work than anything any of us decided on purpose."

"That's not his fault."

"No. It is not his fault, and it is the thing he cannot put down, and those are not the same." Ivo turned the notebook over in his hands. "It is why I wrote it down twice. When Teddy said the story would be that I rang the bell, I said yes, out loud, in the room, like everybody else. And then I went upstairs and wrote the true version and left it above the false one on the same page, because it was the only thing I could think of at nineteen that was not either speaking or lying."

"You could have gone to the police."

"Yes," said Ivo. "I could have gone to the police. I have had four hundred and twenty-six nights to think of that, and I know the number because I have written down every one of them."

"Who rang it?"

Ivo picked up the notebook and took the rubber band off it and opened it at the page with the two headings, and turned it round on the boards so that it faced her.

"Read the first entry again," he said. "All of it. You copied four words and you left the fifth line."

Nell bent over it in the light of the bare bulb.

Bell, 11pm, 18 min. Wind rising. Argument in the loft, T and C, did not stay. M went down after her.

And under it, in the same fast ordinary hand, one more line she had not had time to read in a room with a door open and a boy in the corridor.

S rang it for her. Told him she was out. He did not ask why.

Margot's Account

Margot was waiting for her at the bottom of the tower stairs the next morning at half past six, dressed, with her coat on.

"Ivo told you."

"Ivo told me."

"Then get your shoes. I am not doing this in a building."

They went up the track in the half dark, past the chapel, and at the fork Margot went left without breaking stride, and Nell followed her down into the hollow, and the two of them stood in front of a stone arch with a wedged door and a greased padlock and the word ICE cut into the lintel above.

"Here," Margot said. "You may as well hear it here. I have not been able to come down here on my own since it happened and I find that I can do it if there is somebody with me, which is a disgusting thing to discover about yourself."

She sat down on the frozen bank with her arms round her knees.

"Ask me," she said.

"Did you push her?"

"I have asked myself that question, I would estimate, four thousand times." Margot looked at the door. "And the true answer is the one nobody will accept, which is that I do not know, and that I have never known, and that the not knowing is the whole of my life now."

"Tell me what happened."

So she did, and it took four minutes, because it had taken eleven.

She had come down the hill about a minute behind. Cassia had already got the door open and gone in. There was a torch on a nail inside and she had it lit and she

was on her knees by the crate where the folder was, and there were four steps down from the door into the chamber, stone, worn, wet in January.

They had argued at the top of the steps.

"It was not even an argument by then," Margot said. "It was the same argument we had had for four hours. I said, wait until the morning. I said, wait a week. I said, you can do this in the summer term and it will still be true in the summer term, and she said, if it is true it does not go stale, and I said, do not do this to Perdita, and she said, Perdita did it to herself, and she was right, and I hated her for being right at half past eleven at night on a hill."

"And then?"

"And then she picked up the folder and came up the steps to go past me, and I put my hand on her arm."

Margot held up her right hand. In the grey light the scar across the palm was very clear.

"I had the torch in this one. I put this hand on her arm, to keep her there, because I had not finished, because I had one more thing to say and I have never in my life been able to remember what it was." Her voice was completely level. "And she pulled away from me. That is all. She pulled her arm away, the way you do, hard, the way you do when someone will not let you past. And she was one step below me on wet stone in the dark."

The wind came over the lip of the hollow.

"I have gone through it a thousand times," Margot said. "Did I hold on? Did I pull? Did I let go too late, so that when she came away it took her backwards? Or did I simply have my hand on her arm, as I say I did, and she pulled, and she fell?" She looked at Nell for the first time. "I do not know. And I want you to understand that I am not saying that to be forgiven. I am saying it because it is the fact, and because everybody I have told has immediately tried to give me one answer or the other, and both of them are a kind of lying."

"What happened to your hand?"

"The torch went out of it when I reached for her and I went down after her onto the floor and put my hand into what was there." Margot turned the palm over and looked at it herself, without interest. "We kept bottles down there. Six years of bottles. One of them broke."

She had shouted. She had shouted for a long time in a stone chamber eight feet under a hill behind a chapel, and nobody had heard, and the bell had been ringing.

"That is the part," Margot said. "If you take one thing away from me, take that. I was down there in the dark with her and I was screaming, and forty feet above my head the bell was going, and I could hear it through the stone, and I thought, somebody will come, somebody is up there, the bell means somebody is up there." Her hands were shaking now, for the first time. "And it was Sam. Being kind. Making a noise so that a girl who was already dead would not get a black mark on a rota."

Nell sat down on the bank next to her because she could not stand up any more.

"Was she dead when you got to her?"

"I do not know that either," said Margot. "I am not a doctor and I was eighteen and there was no light. I have said yes for fourteen months and I will say yes for the rest of my life and I do not know."

"Why didn't you go for help?"

"I did."

Nell turned her head.

"I went up that hill," Margot said, "and I went into that loft, and I said the words. I said, she has fallen, she is at the bottom of the steps, she is not moving, get somebody. And there were three of them in that room and they were nineteen years old and every one of us has to live with what happened in the next four minutes."

"What happened in the next four minutes?"

"Teddy stood up," said Margot, "and he was very calm, and he said, is she breathing. And I said I do not know. And he said, right, and he went down with Perdita to look, and Ivo stayed with me because I could not walk, and they came back up in nine minutes, and Teddy said, she is dead, and Perdita was sick on the stairs."

"And then?"

"And then Teddy said the sentence." Margot's face did not move. "He said: if we ring an ambulance now, they will ask what she was doing down there, and it will all come out, all of it, the paper, everything, and it will not bring her back, and Margot will be arrested tonight."

"That's a lie," Nell said. "That's not how any of it works."

"Of course it is a lie," said Margot. "I know that now. I knew it within a month. He was nineteen and terrified and he made it up on a staircase in eleven seconds and it was the most persuasive thing anybody has ever said to me, because I was the one who was going to be arrested."

"So you said yes."

"I said nothing at all," Margot said. "Which is the same as yes, and I have stopped pretending it is not. And Teddy went and woke an adult, and after that it stopped being ours."

She got up and brushed the frost off her coat.

"You want to know why I lied about the padlock at breakfast," she said. "That day, in February. I have thought about that too, because it was the stupidest thing I did in fourteen months, and it was the thing that told you everything."

"Why did you?"

"Because you said the words ice house at a table with butter and toast on it," said Margot, "and I had to say something, and I have never once in my life been able to say I do not know."

"Margot," Nell said. "Why are you telling me? You are the only one of the five with something to lose that cannot be got back."

Margot considered it seriously, which was one of the things Nell had always liked about her and would go on liking about her for a very long time, through everything that came afterwards.

"Two reasons and one of them is not creditable," she said. "The creditable one is that she was my friend and I have spent fourteen months being the only person alive who knows exactly what happened on those steps, and it is not a thing a person can hold on their own. Ivo has a version. Teddy has a version. Only I was there."

"And the other?"

"The other is that I am tired, and I want it to stop, and I do not much care any more what the stopping costs me." She said it without any drama at all. "That is not courage. Courage would have been the fifteenth of January. This is a person who has run out."

"That's still a reason."

"It is a reason," Margot agreed. "It is not a virtue. You are going to spend a long time being told by people that what you did this term was brave, and I would like you to have heard at least one person say the true thing, which is that most of us do the right thing only after every other option has been used up."

They walked back up out of the hollow. At the top Margot stopped and looked back down at the door.

"You are going to open that," she said. It was not a question. "Do it soon. Do it before the twenty-first, because after the twenty-first everybody goes home for four weeks, and I have watched what four weeks does. It sets. It comes back in April a bit smoother, a bit more finished, and one year it will come back as something that never happened at all."

Dr. Fenn

Nell knocked on the door of the Fenn Room at seven o'clock on the Thursday evening, which was the last Thursday of term, and Dr. Fenn said come in without asking who it was.

The fire was in. The typewriter was on the side table. There was a chair drawn up to the desk on the near side, and Nell understood, sitting down in it, that it had been drawn up in advance.

"You have been to Dunleavy," Dr. Fenn said, "and to the governors' minutes, and you got into this office through the hatch on the night of the ninth, and you have spoken to Lindqvist and to Renard, in that order, in the last three days." She put down her pen. "You have not been careful. You have been quick, which is a different thing and mostly a better one, but you should know that in a building of this size you have never once been invisible."

"Did you know about the paper?"

"In November? No." Dr. Fenn folded her hands. "I want to answer everything you ask me tonight exactly and completely, because you will not get this again and neither will I. No. I did not know. I read out a paper by a girl who had beaten four cheats without knowing they were cheating, and I made a small speech about her to the room, and I have thought about that a great deal since."

"And on the night."

"Ashworth-Kane came to my door at eleven minutes to midnight on the fourteenth of January," said Dr. Fenn. "I know the time because I was working and I looked at the clock, which is a thing I do when I am interrupted, and I have never been able to decide whether it is fortunate or unfortunate that I did."

"What did he say?"

"He said, there has been an accident, and she is dead, and Margot did it, and please come."

"And you went."

"I went."

"And?"

Dr. Fenn was quiet for a moment. The coal shifted.

"And I stood in an eighteenth century ice house at twenty past midnight," she said, "with a torch, and I looked at a girl I had taught for five years, and I understood in about four seconds that she had been dead for some time and that there was nothing whatever to be done for her, and that there were four other children standing behind me in the dark."

"You didn't call anybody."

"I called the head," said Dr. Fenn. "At six minutes past one, from the telephone in this room. He came down and he stood where I had stood. And then there were three adults, because he woke the bursar, and by four in the morning there were decisions, and I was in the room for all of them, and I did not leave the room, and I want that on the record because there is a version of this in which I am a woman who was elsewhere."

"Whose idea was the letter?"

"Mine," said Dr. Fenn.

Nell had been ready for a great many answers and she had not been ready for that one, delivered flat, with no shading whatever.

"You typed it on that."

"I typed it on that, at about half past four in the morning, and I put the date of the fourteenth on it, and I took a signature off a consent form in her file and I put it in front of the head, and he signed the leavers' entry the next day." Dr. Fenn's face was entirely still. "I have never once said that I did not. You are the fourth person to ask me and you are the first who was owed an answer."

"Why?"

"That is the right question and I will give you the true answer rather than the good one." She sat back. "Because at four in the morning on the fifteenth of January the head of this school was going to telephone the police, and the bursar was going to telephone the family's solicitor, and I sat in that room and I did the arithmetic that I have done in every room I have ever been in, which is: what happens to the children."

"She was a child."

"She was dead," said Dr. Fenn. "That is not callousness, it is the entire hinge of it, and if you cannot hold it you will not understand a thing that happened afterwards. Nothing that anybody did after half past eleven that night could reach her. Everything that anybody did after half past eleven that night could reach the other five."

"So you decided."

"I decided that a girl of eighteen who had put her hand on someone's arm on a wet step would be tried in a newspaper before she was tried anywhere else, and that Ollerenshaw would be expelled and would not recover from it, and that a boy on a bursary from Manchester would lose the only reference he had, and that this school would be closed within four years, and that four hundred children a year would go somewhere worse." Dr. Fenn did not raise her voice at any point. "And I decided that against one thing on the other side, which was the truth, and I decided that the truth had no living body to protect. And I was wrong, and I knew within a fortnight that I was wrong, and I have not changed one single arrangement since, which is the part you should hold against me."

"Why not?"

"Because by then there were five children whose lives depended on the arrangement holding," said Dr. Fenn, "and because a person who does a thing like this discovers very quickly that there is no second decision. There is one decision and then there is fourteen months of maintenance."

Nell's hands were cold in a warm room.

"And me," she said.

"Yes," said Dr. Fenn. "And you. Now we come to it."

"You wrote to the bursar on the sixteenth."

"I did."

"Two days after."

"Two days after."

"Say it," Nell said. "I've read the letter. I want to hear you say it."

Dr. Fenn looked at her for a long moment, and then did something Nell had not seen her do in eleven weeks, which was to take off her glasses.

"I read four hundred words by a seventeen year old in Hull in November," she said, "and I went to the governors in November and told them I would bring them a case in March, and I meant it, and I would have done it, and you would have come

here in September of this year with a proper award after a proper process, and none of the rest of this would have had anything to do with you." She set the glasses on the desk. "And on the sixteenth of January there was an empty room at the top of the West Tower, and an office that would have to explain, at some point, to somebody, why a place was standing open in the middle of a year. And I looked at the thing I already wanted, and I saw that it had become useful, and I did it seven months early."

"So which was it?"

"Both," said Dr. Fenn. "That is the answer, and you will not like it, and it will be true for the rest of your life. I wanted you here before I needed you here. And then I needed you here, and the wanting made the needing look like an act of generosity, including to me. That is how it is done, Eleanor. Nobody sits down and decides to use a child. They notice that a good thing has become convenient and they do not examine the convenience."

The fire. The clock.

"You put me in her room," Nell said.

"The office put you in her room, because it was the room that was free, and I did not stop them." Dr. Fenn's voice went, for one syllable, somewhere else. "I have made a number of cold decisions in my life and I sleep adequately after most of them. That one, no."

Nell stood up.

"There is an offer," she said. "Teddy made it in the library. I assume it's yours."

"It is not mine. It is his, and he means it, and it is worth having." Dr. Fenn put her glasses back on. "Mine is smaller and I will make it once. Whatever you do next, you will do it, and I will not put a hand out to stop you, and I will not warn anybody, and when it is done I will tell the truth about my own part in it to whoever asks me, first, before I am pushed, and without a solicitor."

"That's not an offer. That's the least you could do."

"Yes," said Dr. Fenn. "It is exactly the least I could do. I have not offered you the least I could do because I thought it would impress you. I have offered it because it is the only thing I have left that is worth anything, and because you are going to need somebody in this building to say it out loud, and every other adult here will say we were misled by the children."

She picked up her pen and drew the next paper towards her.

"Shut the door behind you," she said. "It swells in the damp."

Sam

He was in the boot room, which was where he always was, and he had known she was coming, which by then she expected of everybody.

"Ivo told you about the bell," he said.

"Ivo told me about the bell."

Sam nodded slowly. He was sitting on the bench with his elbows on his knees and his hands hanging, and he did not look up.

"I've been waiting for that since the second week of January," he said. "You have no idea what it is like, waiting fourteen months for one specific sentence and then finding out that it is a relief."

"You lied to me on the first day."

"I did."

"You lied to me on the road, about the scholarship, and in the queue, and you told me the bell was rung badly by somebody, and it was you."

"Yes."

"Say why."

"Because she wasn't in the building at five to eleven," Sam said, "and the chaplain writes it down when somebody misses the bell, and it goes to your tutor, and Cassia already had two black marks that term for the sort of thing that Cassia got black marks for, which was arguing with people who were wrong." He rubbed his face. "Teddy came down and said, Cass is out, she's not going to make the bell, cover her. And I said fine. And I went and did eighteen minutes. And I did it badly because I have rung that bell four times in my life and Ivo has rung it four hundred times, and that is the entire story of the worst thing I have ever done."

"That's not the worst thing you've done."

"No," said Sam. "It isn't. I know what the worst thing is. Ask me."

Nell stood in a cold room full of other people's boots.

"Who asked you to look after me?"

He looked up at last.

"Fenn," he said. "On the fourth of January, before you arrived. She sent for me and she said, there is a girl coming from Hull in a fortnight into the top of the West Tower, and she will know nobody, and she is the only other person in this school who will understand what it costs to be here on somebody else's money, and I am asking you to be her friend."

"And you said yes."

"I said yes in about two seconds, and I want you to know that it was not a hard decision and that I did not think there was anything wrong with it, because there was not." He said it steadily. "That is what she does. She has done it to four people since I got here. It is one of the few genuinely good things in this entire institution and I have never heard anybody say a word against it."

"But."

"But," Sam agreed. "But she asked me on the fourth of January. Which was three weeks after Cassia was dead and eleven days before you arrived. And she knew, and I knew, and neither of us said one word about that, and I walked out of that room and went and worked out how to be useful to you."

"The window catch," Nell said.

"The window catch."

"You were waiting for me in Hall on the first night."

"I was waiting for you in Hall on the first night."

"The shop. Bernie. The chocolate."

"All of it," Sam said. "Every single thing I did in your first fortnight I did on purpose, and I did it well, because I am good at it, and because being useful to people who have power over me is the skill I have had to build since I was thirteen years old in this place." His voice did not break but it thinned. "And then about three weeks in it stopped being that. And I have not been able to tell where the line was, and I have gone back over it, and I cannot find the day. Which means you cannot either, and you never will, and I have understood for a month that this is the actual punishment."

Nell found she was holding on to the edge of the bench.

"Was any of it real?"

"That is not a question I get to answer," said Sam. "You know that. If I say yes, I am doing the thing I do. The only honest answer available to me is that I would say yes either way."

He reached into his coat, into the inside pocket, and took out an envelope.

He held it for a second before he gave it to her.

"I typed this last night," he said. "In the Fenn Room, on her machine, because it seemed like the only decent joke left in this building. It is three pages. It is everything I did and everything I saw and every date I am sure of and every date I am not, and it says at the top that I am making it of my own free will and that nobody has offered me anything, which is true, and at the bottom I have signed it."

Nell did not take it at once.

"Did Teddy tell you to give me that?"

"No."

"Did Fenn?"

"No." Sam almost smiled. "You are asking the right question and you are asking it too late, which is the story of both of us. Nobody told me. I will say something else, though, and you can do what you like with it, because you are going to be checking everything anybody says to you for the rest of your life and you may as well start with this." He turned the envelope over in his hands. "There is no version of the next six months in which I come out of it better by having written that. Not one. If I say nothing, I am a boy who rang a bell as a favour and was lied to by his friends, and I keep my reference, and in September I am somewhere else and none of this ever attaches to my name. That is available to me. It has been available to me all week and it will be available to me until the moment you walk down that hill."

"Then don't."

"That is not on offer either," Sam said, "because I have had fourteen months of being a boy who rang a bell as a favour, and it turns out that the story you tell about yourself at three in the morning is not the one in the reference."

Nell took the envelope. It was warm from his pocket.

"Sam, if you give me this, you are finished here."

"I am finished here anyway. I have been finished here since eleven o'clock on the fourteenth of January and it has taken me fourteen months to stop negotiating about it." He put his hands back in his pockets. "The reference is gone. My place is gone. My mother is going to ask me a question in about a week that I have not

worked out how to answer. All of that is happening whatever either of us does now."

"Then why?"

"Because you cannot do this on your own," Sam said, "and everybody in this school knows it, including you."

He stood up.

"You are eighteen and you have been here nine weeks and you are on their money," he said. "You will walk into a police station with a notebook from a village shop and a laundry docket, and somewhere behind you there will be a school with a solicitor and a hundred and forty families and a very good story about a scholarship girl who became obsessed with the room she was put in. I know exactly how that goes. So does Fenn. So does Teddy, which is why he was so calm in that library."

"And a statement changes it."

"A statement from the other scholarship kid, who has no reason on earth to make one, changes it completely," Sam said. "It is the only thing I have that is worth anything to you, and it is the only thing I have that is worth anything at all, and I have thought about it for a month and I would rather give it to you than keep it."

He went to the door and stopped with his hand on it, the way he had on the first night.

"One more," he said. "Because you have not asked and you should, and because I would rather say it than have you work it out on the train in the summer."

"Go on."

"You asked me on the hill at Lantern Night what I wanted from you." He did not turn round. "The answer that night was that I wanted you to like me, because I had been told to make you, and because by then I had also begun to. And the answer now is different, and it is worse, and it is this."

He opened the door onto the dark and the wet gravel.

"I want you to be the one who does it," Sam said, "because I have known for fourteen months and I never did, and if you go down that hill on Saturday then for the rest of my life I get to have been the person who helped, instead of the person who rang the bell."

The Ice House

She did it on the Saturday, which was the nineteenth of March, two days before the end of term.

She was awake at five. She had not slept much and she had stopped pretending that lying still was the same as resting, so she got up in the dark and washed in cold water and put on the clothes she had arrived in, which she had not worn since January.

Then she sat at the desk in room fourteen and did the last piece of work.

She wrote out, by hand, on eleven sheets of school paper, everything she had, in order, with the source of each item and the date she had got it, and where the thing itself could be found. The laundry docket. The rota. The leavers' list with no second line. The schedule of awards. The governors' minutes for November, item 7. The requisition slip on the spike, signed A. Fenn, and the photocopy in the wire tray marked TO BE FILED. Dunleavy's ledger. Ivo's notebook with two entries for one day. The photograph on the back of which somebody had written all six of us.

She did not write down what any of it meant. She had learned that in the first week from a woman she was about to destroy: you write it down before you interpret it, or you will find you have written down the interpretation.

At the top she put her name and her address in Hull, and the date.

She put the eleven sheets and Sam's envelope into a plastic wallet, and she put the whole thing inside her coat, and she went down the sixty-one stairs at ten to seven in the morning.

Dunleavy was in the workshop with the stove lit. He looked at her once and then reached up to the board and took the key off its hook and put it in his pocket without a word.

"I'm going to the village first," Nell said. "I'm going to telephone the police from the shop. I'd like you to come up to the door and wait, and not open it, and if anybody from this school comes down that hill before I get back, I would like you to say that you are following an instruction from the estates ledger, which is true, and to keep standing there."

"Aye," said Dunleavy.

"You don't have to."

"I've said I would." He put another log in the stove and shut it. "You'll want a lift down. It's two mile and it's icy and you'll be an hour."

Bernie drove her, in a car with a dog blanket on the back seat and a service light on the dash that had been on since 2021.

She did not ask one question on the way down. At the bottom of the hill, where the road came round by the wall, she pulled in and stopped and left the engine running, and looked straight ahead through the windscreen.

"That lass they were asking about last winter," she said.

"Yes."

"I said to them, if there'd been a lass on that road she'd not have got as far as my gate." Bernie's hands stayed on the wheel. "I've thought about that a fair bit since, and I want to say it to somebody before you go in and use my telephone. They asked me the wrong question and I gave them a right answer, and they went off satisfied, and I let them."

"That isn't your fault."

"No," said Bernie. "It isn't. But I've lived in this valley fifty-one years and that school has been up there the whole time, and I have never once in my life thought that anything that happened inside them gates was anything to do with me." She put the car back into gear. "You're eighteen and you've been here ten weeks and you've thought different. That's all I want to say about it."

She parked outside the shop and unlocked it and turned the lights on and stood behind the counter with her arms folded while Nell used the telephone on the wall by the crisps.

It took four minutes. Nell had written down what she was going to say and she read it, because she did not trust her own voice to construct sentences.

"My name is Eleanor Kavanagh. I am a student at Ravensfell College. I am telephoning about a girl called Cassia Brandt, who this school recorded as having withdrawn on the fourteenth of January last year. She did not withdraw. She died on

the estate that night, and I believe her body is in a building on the estate, and I believe I can tell you which one and who locked it and on what date and on whose written authority."

There was a pause on the line of about two seconds.

Then the voice at the other end changed, in a way that Nell recognised, because it was the same change she had heard in Perdita's voice in room fourteen when the gin had stopped working: a person going from one job to a different one.

"Right," the voice said. "Stay exactly where you are, please, and give me that name again."

They came in thirty-five minutes, which Bernie said afterwards was the fastest she had ever known anything to happen in that valley.

A police car, and then a second one, and a woman in plain clothes who was not in uniform and who took Nell into the back of the shop and read the eleven sheets straight through without speaking, and then read Sam's three pages, and then went outside and made a telephone call standing in the road for a long time.

When she came back in she said, "Eleanor, I want you to understand that from this point you do not have to do anything else at all. You have done it."

"I'd like to come up," Nell said.

"You do not need to be there."

"I'd like to come up," Nell said again, "as far as the top of the hollow. Not down to the door. There's a man waiting at the door who has been standing there since seven o'clock in the cold because I asked him to, and he is sixty-two and he has worked there for thirty-one years, and I would like him to see that I came back."

She stood at the top of the hollow at twenty past nine on the nineteenth of March with the wind coming across three hundred acres of moor and the frost still white in the shadow of the bank.

There were seven of them down there in the end. They put a light on a stand. Somebody photographed the door before anybody touched it, and then photographed the wedge at the foot of it, and a man with a bag knelt down and did something to it for a long time.

Dunleavy had said he would put the key in the lock himself, and they would not let him, which he had probably known. So he did the other half of it instead.

He stood in front of the woman in plain clothes with his ledger open in both hands like a hymn book, and he read out the entry, out loud, in a voice that carried up the bank to where Nell was standing: padlock, brass, long shackle, fifteenth of

January, authority head's office, and the price, which was eleven pounds and forty pence.

Then he handed her the key and stepped back three paces and took his cap off, which nobody had asked him to do.

The padlock came off cleanly. It had been greased in January of the previous year and it had been greased well.

They took the door out of the frame rather than opening it, because of the wedge, and two of them carried it away and leaned it on the bank.

Then there was the black square of the doorway, and the four stone steps going down, and a torch on a nail on the wall inside, exactly where a torch had hung since five children were fourteen years old.

Nell watched them go in, one at a time, ducking.

She did not see anything. She wants that understood, she said, years later, to the only person she ever told the whole of it to: she did not see anything at all. She was ninety feet away at the top of a bank in the wind, and the light was inside, and after the second officer went down there was a long quiet, and then a man came up the steps and stood in the doorway and put both hands on the lintel above his head and stayed like that for a moment, and then turned and said something over his shoulder to the woman behind him.

That was all. A man standing in a doorway with his hands on the stone.

Afterwards, Nell could never explain to anybody why that was the moment, out of everything that happened that term, that she was unable to think about without having to stop and put something down.

At ten o'clock the woman in plain clothes came up the bank to her, and stood next to her, and looked out at the moor rather than at her, which was a kindness.

"Is it her?" Nell said.

"We are not going to say that today, and when we do say it, it will not be to you first, it will be to her mother." The woman put her hands in her coat pockets. "But I am not going to stand here and let you think you have wasted anybody's morning."

"No."

"No," the woman agreed.

Below them, more cars were coming up the drive, and somebody had begun to put blue and white tape across the mouth of the hollow, and away over the roofs of the college the bell in the clock tower struck ten, exactly as it had struck ten every day since 1847, and would go on striking, because a bell does not know anything.

The Withdrawal Form

The term did not end. It stopped.

There was no last day, no packing bell, no coaches on the gravel at eleven o'clock on the twenty-first. There was a Saturday with police cars on the drive, and a Sunday when the head sent a letter to a hundred and forty families that Nell never read, and by the Monday there were parents' cars coming up under the beeches all day, and boys and girls carrying bags out to them, and a man from a newspaper standing at the gates being moved along by a constable and coming back nine minutes later.

Nell stayed. She had nowhere to be until the Thursday, when her mother could get a day off, and there was nobody in the building with any authority to tell her to go, and the strangest week of her life was the one in which a school of a hundred and forty people emptied around a girl from Hull who sat in the library because it was warm.

She was interviewed twice, in the head's outer office, with the woman in plain clothes and a second officer and a duty solicitor she had not asked for and was told firmly to accept. It took eleven hours over two days. They went through the eleven sheets line by line, and every single item on them was a thing that could be gone and looked at, and by the second afternoon Nell understood, from the way the questions changed, that they were no longer testing her.

On the Tuesday she saw the five of them for the last time all together.

She was coming across the Old Quad in the rain at half past four and they came out of the chapel in a line, and afterwards she could never work out what they had been doing in there, and never asked.

Perdita first, in her coat, with her hair down, holding her own arms. Then Ivo, with the notebook under his jacket to keep the rain off it, because he had given the original to the police on the Saturday and had bought another one in Hexham on the Monday and had already started it. Then Margot, who had been interviewed for six hours and who was going to be interviewed a great deal more, and who was walking the way a person walks when they have put something down.

Then Teddy. Then Sam.

They stopped when they saw her. All five of them, in the rain, twenty feet away.

Nobody said anything for a moment. There was nothing available to say. A hundred small things had ended between six people and there was no form of words.

Then Perdita crossed the gravel and put her arms round Nell's neck, hard, without a single line of dialogue, which for Perdita Ollerenshaw was the most extraordinary thing she ever did, and let go, and went back.

Margot said, "Good."

That was all. One word, in the rain, and Nell understood it completely.

Teddy said, "Kavanagh." He put his hand out, the way he had in the clock loft in January, and Nell looked at it and did not take it, and Teddy took it back without any embarrassment at all and said, "No. Quite right." And then, because he was who he was to the very end: "It was a real offer, you know."

"I know," Nell said. "That's why it was worth refusing."

And Sam, last, at the back, did not come forward and did not speak, and lifted one hand about six inches, and Nell lifted hers, and that was the last time she saw him for eleven years.

On the Wednesday morning she went to the office.

Mrs. Enderby was at her desk, which she had been every day of that week, doing the eleven lists in reverse for a hundred and forty children, and she looked up and her face did something complicated.

"I need the form," Nell said. "For withdrawing."

"Eleanor."

"I know what you're going to say."

"I am going to say that nobody has asked you to go," said Mrs. Enderby, "and that nobody is going to, and that Dr. Fenn told me on Sunday, in this room, before she went in to be interviewed, that if there was any question of your award she

would fund it herself, and that I was to write that down and put it on your file, which I did."

"I know. She told me."

"Then why?"

Nell had thought about how to answer that for four days and she had not found a way that did not sound either grand or ungrateful, and in the end she gave the true one, which was neither.

"Because I would be here on it," she said. "Every day. In a room I was put in because a place was free. I would do the work and I would go to Oxford and I would be glad, and every single year of my life I would know exactly what the money was for." She put her hands in her pockets. "And I would get used to it. That's the bit. I'd get used to it by about the second year. I've watched five people get used to something much worse in fourteen months, and they're not monsters, they're just people who stayed."

Mrs. Enderby looked at her for a moment.

Then she opened the drawer and took out the form.

It was one side of A4, and it had the school crest at the top, and it was, Nell noticed, the same paper the withdrawal letter had been typed on.

"You may write it by hand," Mrs. Enderby said.

"Can I use the machine in the Fenn Room?"

"She has gone to her sister's in Durham until the hearing," said Mrs. Enderby. "The room is open. The fire is not lit and I am not going to light it."

The Fenn Room in the last week of March was cold, and grey, and the fire was a heap of ash, and the papers on the desk had been squared by somebody who was not coming back for a while.

Nell wound the form into the roller and set the margin and typed.

I am writing to confirm that I am withdrawing from Ravensfell College with effect from the end of this term. I am not doing so for family reasons. I am doing so because I do not want to hold this place. I would like it to be recorded that Dr. Fenn offered to fund my award personally and that I refused, and that no member of staff asked me to leave.

She read it back.

The e sat high in every word. Every single one. Wanting, recorded, member, refused, effect, the whole page speckled with a letter that had been standing on tiptoe since 2015, exactly as it had in a letter typed at half past four on the morning

of the fifteenth of January by a woman who had decided what happens to the children.

Nell looked at it for a long time.

Then she signed it, in blue ink, small and cramped, at the bottom, and took it down to the office, and Mrs. Enderby stamped it and put it on the spike.

She went up to room fourteen one more time, to strip the bed, because there was nobody left in the tower to do it and it seemed wrong to leave it.

The wardrobe was empty. They had taken everything on the Saturday, in bags, with labels on them, and had been extremely careful about it, and had asked her twice whether she was all right, and she had said yes twice and had gone and stood in the corridor.

The green coat had gone. The dress in its dry cleaner's bag had gone, with the ticket still stapled to it, 04/01, BRANDT C. The shoebox had gone, and the photograph in it of five people on the chapel steps in July with a sixth half out of frame in the doorway, and on the back, in pencil, in a hand that sloped hard to the right, the words all six of us.

Nell had asked about the photograph, at the second interview, whether it had been Cassia's writing.

The woman in plain clothes had said that she could not discuss it, and then, after a pause that was itself an answer, had asked Nell what she thought.

"I think there were six of them," Nell had said. "Whoever took the picture was one of them too. I think she counted the person holding the camera, and I do not think anybody else in that group would have."

She folded the blankets and squared them at the foot of the bed the way her mother did.

Then she put her father's watch, which had stopped in 2019 and which she had never had mended, into the inside pocket of her coat, and looked once round a small cold room at the top of a tower with a window whose catch was broken, and pulled the door to behind her.

Her mother came for her on the Thursday on the eleven forty from Newcastle, and they walked down the drive together under the beeches with the case between them because Nell would not let her carry it and she would not let Nell carry it either, and at the gates Nell turned round once.

The building came out of the fog the way it had in January, all at once, the way a ship does. Three windows lit. Everything else dark.

On the platform at Hexham there was the same board and the same wind and the same smell of cold iron, and the train came in on time going the other way, back down the line towards Newcastle and the coast and the flat brown estuary that was not the sea.

"You did right," her mother said, when they were sitting down.

"I know."

"You'll not always know it."

"No," Nell said.

She had eleven weeks until the summer exams, at a school on Newland Avenue where a woman called Mrs. Aspinall had already telephoned twice to say that her place was open and that there was a university admissions scheme for exactly this and that she should not, under any circumstances, let a single person tell her that this was the end of anything.

Nell put her head against the window and watched the moor go past and turn into fields, and thought about a girl who had spent six weeks deciding whether reporting four sides of A4 was a proportionate thing to do, and who had decided that it was.

It does not go stale, if it is true.

The train came down out of the hills into the light, and Ravensfell College went on standing where it had stood since 1783, and the bell rang at eleven o'clock that night, because somebody was on the rota.

A Word Before You Go

Thank you for reading *The Winter Term*.

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It matters more than it sounds like it should.

With thanks, Maren Ashcroft

Also by Maren Ashcroft

The Second-Hand Spellbook: A Cozy Fantasy Novel

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About the Author

Maren Ashcroft writes literary suspense set in closed institutions: schools, colleges, and the small cold places where everyone has known everyone since they were thirteen. *THE WINTER TERM* is her first dark academia mystery.